



Hindustan Times

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New Delhi, India

BUILDING FOR RESILIENCE, INNOVATION,
COOPERATION AND SUSTAINABILITY

Prosperity through Collaboration

Oil near a 5-week high as West Asia crisis escalates

Bloomberg

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DUBAI: Oil steadied near the highest closing level in five weeks as hostilities broke out again between the US and Iran, renewing the threat to energy exports from the Middle East. West Texas Intermediate traded near \$90 a barrel after surging 5.2% on Tuesday, while Brent hovered close to \$95. The US conducted a second day of strikes on the Islamic Republic overnight, with President Donald Trump threatening more attacks if Tehran responded. Within hours, Iran retaliated against Jordan, Bahrain and Kuwait, countries that host American forces.

The return to a hot war has once again put shipping through the vital Strait of Hormuz in jeopardy, as the two nations remain at loggerheads, and diplomatic efforts yield few results. The US struck two Iranian vessels Tuesday under a new "tanker-for-tanker" policy approved by Trump. Axios reported, citing American officials, that about a day earlier, two oil super-tankers attempting to exit the strait were

Biggest exchange of strikes since July

West Asia feared a return of war on Wednesday after the biggest exchange of fire between Tehran and Washington since July, with US striking Iran's southern coast and Iran firing at American bases

"You will soon see that Iran's new strategy on the battlefield, in diplomacy, and in confronting the economic blockade will shatter your foundations." — **MOHSEN REZAEI**, Iran Supreme National Security Council secretary

"Now that we have it under US control, should we change the name Hormuz Strait to TRUMP STRAIT??? Like America itself? It would be 'hotter' than ever before!" — **DONALD TRUMP**, US President



Damage and debris at a building that Iran said was hit by a US strike, in Kuestak, Iran

reported to have been hit by projectiles.

"The market is now clearly pricing in a direct military confrontation, while the prospect of a negotiated solution has diminished," said Arne Lohmann-Basmissen, chief analyst at Global Risk Management in Copenhagen. "This is a worse combination for the energy market than the situation we faced just a few days ago and even in April."

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SEVERAL KILLED AT WEDDING IN U.S. STRIKE: IRAN
AUS strike hit a home hosting a wedding in Kuestak, a town overlooking the Strait of Hormuz, according to Iranian state media. Four people were killed — two women and two children — and at least 68 were wounded, the state news agency IRNA and state TV said Wednesday. Ahmad Nafisi, the province's deputy governor, told Iranian state television that five people were killed. Images from Tasnim news

agency showed hospitalised children being treated for injuries at a hospital in Minab, where a US missile strike on the opening day of the war hit a primary school, killing more than 100 children. "Make no mistake: these crimes will not go unpunished," Ebrahim Azizi, chairman of the Iranian parliament's National Security and Foreign Policy Committee, said. US Central Command was "looking into" the Iranian reports. AGENCIES

SC PLACES BCI OPS UNDER INCREASED OVERSIGHT, AG, SG NOW HAVE ROLE

Utaksh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday put the functioning of the Bar Council of India (BCI) under a tighter oversight mechanism, directing that the Attorney General and Solicitor General be "actively associated" with every policy decision taken by the body, until it is reconstituted through fresh elections. The bench also said BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra's continuance in office cannot be treated as an arrangement extending up to 2030. →

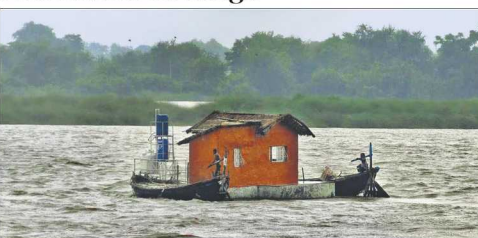
25K CATTLE ON CITY STREETS: MCD SEEKS MORE SHELTERS TO TACKLE PROBLEM

Paras Singh

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NEW DELHI: The stray cattle problem is far bigger than the city's existing shelters can handle. Over 25,000 cattle are estimated to be roaming the city, according to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's veterinary department, while its four cow shelters are already overcrowded. Currently, around 50-60 cows are being picked up every day. We need at least five large cow shelters," a veterinary official said.

Flood threat on Ganga



Boats carry a hut down the Ganga in Patna. Rains lashed several parts of Bihar on Wednesday, causing water levels in major rivers to rise. The Ganga's water level in Varanasi also crossed the warning mark on Wednesday. SANTOSH KUMAR/HI PHOTO

Pilot who crashed in Pak quits IAF, joins pvt airline

Rahul Singh

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NEW DELHI: Group Captain Abhinandan Varthman, who was awarded the Vir Chakra for shooting down a Pakistani F-16 during a dogfight over the Line of Control on February 27, 2019, has quit the Indian Air Force and joined a private airline, officials said on Wednesday.

He left the IAF on March 31 and later joined

Flyr1, a regional carrier, the officials said asking not to be named. Abhinandan, then 35, scripted military aviation history by downing an F-16, seconds before being hit by a missile fired from the Pakistani F-16. He was the first ever kill of an F-16 by a MiG-21 Bison, fighter jets of two different generations. He was captured after he bailed out of his aircraft, but Pakistan returned him to India on March 1, 2019, after almost 60 hours. →

EX-BUREAUCRAT PICKED UP BY COPS AT PARK, QUIZZED

Karn Pratap Singh

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NEW DELHI: Former bureaucrat Ashish Joshi was detained by Delhi Police on Wednesday and questioned for over eight hours at the counter-intelligence unit in New Friends Colony in connection with a case registered by the special cell, before being dropped home in the evening, police officers said. Joshi was picked up from Nehru Park while he was out on a morning walk, said his friends.

BANKS MOBILISE \$127 BN DEPOSITS FROM NRIs: RBI

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MUMBAI: The RBI's FCNR(B) scheme drew \$127.2 billion from non-resident Indians, accounting for 93.3% of the \$136.4 billion raised under its dollar-inflow initiative by August 31. The surge in dollar deposits significantly boosted banking-system liquidity, reducing banks' dependence on short-term wholesale funding. Three-month CD rates consequently fell to 6.3% from around 7.1% when the scheme began. →

→ XRPUS INDIA'S CREDIT RATING TO A, P2

GLOBAL TEMP RISE TO EXCEED 1.5°C IN FEW YEARS: UNEP

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NEW DELHI: Global temperature rise is likely to cross the 1.5°C threshold by decade-end, pushing climate risks and impacts to dangerous levels, a UN Environment Programme report released on Wednesday said. It said human-induced global warming is nearing 1.4°C above pre-industrial levels and observes that global temperatures have been rising about 0.25°C per decade. →

HIMALAYAN FLOOD TOLL RISES TO 1,243; 4,200 STILL MISSING

Reuters

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KATHMANDU/BEIJING: Rescue teams raced on Wednesday to reach dozens of workers believed to be trapped inside hydropower tunnels in Nepal's mountains, offering one of the last hopes of finding survivors a week after a Himalayan flood killed 1,243. More than 4,200 remain missing.

Rescue efforts have increasingly centred on hydroelectric project tunnels where authorities believe workers may have survived after being cut off by

continued on →

Real estate brochures not just for show, SC warns builders

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has warned the real estate industry that promises made in project brochures cannot be dismissed as mere marketing material, holding that a developer must construct and deliver a project in strict conformity with the representations made in the brochures. The next hearing, it would "need to pass appropriate orders".

IAF, Sindoor veteran is 1st Ram temple CEO

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LUCKNOW: The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Wednesday appointed a former air marshal as its first chief executive officer (CEO) and inducted three new members as it attempted a major restructuring to move on from the swirling controversy over irregularities in donation collections at the Ram Temple.

In two back-to-back meetings, the trust also named incumbent treasurer Govind Dev Giri — who was in the post when the donation row erupted this summer — as the new full-time general secretary. Giri was replaced as treasurer by Delhi-based businessman Mahesh Bhagchandani, who also runs the Ashok Singhal Foundation.

The appointments ended speculation about the return of former trust members Champat Rai and Anil Mishra, who had quit their posts in July.

Air Marshal (retired) Jeet- continued on →

New role after nearly 40 yrs in IAF

5,585

Candidates

Mishra was

picked from

Glittering career

Commissioned into the Indian Air Force in 1986

Mishra served for nearly 40 years, retiring on April 30 this year.

Awarded the Sarvottam Yudh Seva Medal for his role in Operation Sindoor.

Mahesh Bhagchandani, Madan Mohan Pandey and Nirmal Yadav named trustees. Bhagchandani is new treasurer

view with HT. Mishra also said he looked forward to taking on the challenges and responsibilities.

"Till the age of 60, I got the opportunity to serve in the Indian Air Force. And a few months after I retired, I got the opportunity to serve the Shri Ram Temple and the Ram Bhaktas," he said. →

'IAF experience will help me well in the new role'

Rahul Singh

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NEW DELHI: Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (ret), the first chief executive officer of the Ram temple trust, on Wednesday said his four decades of service in the Indian Air Force would serve him well in his new role. In an inter-

view with HT. Mishra also said he looked forward to taking on the challenges and responsibilities. "Till the age of 60, I got the opportunity to serve in the Indian Air Force. And a few months after I retired, I got the opportunity to serve the Shri Ram Temple and the Ram Bhaktas," he said. →

'Concocted': HC quashes DU grad's NSA detention over Noida workers' stir

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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday quashed the detention order against a 25-year-old DU graduate who has been in judicial custody for around five months in connection with the Noida workers' protest of April 2026, saying her detention was based on a "concocted story".

Allowing the habeas corpus petition, a division bench comprising Justice Anil Sreedharan and Justice Achal Sachdev directed the detention order of Akriti Chaudhary if her arrest was not warranted in any other case. The court also directed the state to pay her compensation of ₹5 lakh,

THE DEVELOPMENT CAME AS THE BENCH FOUND SEVERAL LAPSES AFTER EXAMINING THE SEQUENCE OF ARREST AND THE NOTICES ISSUED

according to Charlie Prakash, the petitioner's counsel. The development came as the bench found several lapses after closely examining the sequence of Chaudhary's arrest and the notices issued to her under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita.

SEARCH ON FOR 2 SOLDIERS AS BOAT CAPSIZES IN HRY

KARNAL: A search-and-rescue operation by security and response forces was underway on Wednesday at Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana's Yamunanagar district after two soldiers of the 1 Para Special Forces went missing in the Yamuna during a training exercise after their boat developed a technical snag. The incident happened on Tuesday evening. →

CBI CHARGES 6 IAS OFFICERS IN HRY BANKING FRAUD

PANCHKULA: CBI on Wednesday named six IAS officers in a fresh charge sheet filed in connection with the ₹504-crore DPC First Bank irregularities involving Haryana government departments and organisations, officials said. The alleged financial embezzlement came to light in February this year. →

ICC SHAFHS WOMEN'S CHAMPIONS TROPHY TO INDIA FROM SL

LONDON: The inaugural women's Champions Trophy has been moved to India after Sri Lanka were stripped of hosting rights. The International Cricket Council announced Wednesday. Mumbai and Vadodra will host the 120 matches from February 14 to 28. →



The Primus in Gurugram.

ED SEARCHES 14 PREMISES ACROSS STATES IN NHA1 TOLL FRAUD PROBE

LUCKNOW: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted searches in multiple states as part of a money laundering investigation linked to the "fraudulent" toll collection at various NHA1 places, officials said. They said about 14 premises in UP, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, J&K, Madhya Pradesh, Delhi-NCR and West Bengal were searched. The action was launched on basis of police FIRs that alleged use of unauthorised software applications for generating toll receipts and "diversion" of toll collections. →

{ INDIGO AIRCRAFT } SUSPECTED ENGINE FAILURE

A plan change and a twist of fate: Ex-army chief recalls how emergency unfolded on Goa flight

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NEW DELHI: General JJ Singh (ret) was not supposed to be on Indigo flight 6H 202 at all. The former army chief's initial plan was to fly out to Delhi from Belagavi. But he needed to be in the Capital earlier, so he chose to fly out from Goa's Manohar International Airport instead.

The Airbus A321neo took off at 9.16am. Within minutes, Singh said he heard a loud noise and a hissing sound from one of the engines. And then, silence. The crew alerted air traffic control to a suspected engine failure and requested an immediate return. "The acceleration reduced considerably — it was initially at full thrust going up," Singh told HT. "All of us felt something was wrong. We just didn't know what."

The decorated officer, who also served as governor of Arunachal Pradesh between 2008 and 2013, said panic soon rippled through the cabin as passengers began to fear the worst. Some cried inconsolably, especially a woman who held her three-month-old baby in her lap, he said. "I did my best to reassure my co-passengers that, with god's grace, all will be well," said Singh. To be sure, Indigo did not confirm that the issue was related to the engine. However, a person aware of the matter earlier told HT the issue was

continued on →

HC TELLS CBI TO CONDUCT FRESH PROBE IN DEATH OF DISHA SALIAN

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MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday ordered the CBI to register an FIR and conduct a fresh probe into the death of celebrity manager Disha Salian, observing that the inquiry carried out by the police was "inadequate and raised serious questions that it answered". The court also clarified that "nobody shall be treated as an accused unless, in the opinion of the court, there are sufficient grounds to raise reasonable suspicion against them". →

'I had to learn to win, didn't have strong will'

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BENGALURU: Indian grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa is riding a wave of rich form. Fresh from winning the Grand Chess Tour, the 21-year-old in an interview with HT spoke about his evolution as a player, and how he had to build a winning mentality. "I'm not someone who was naturally ambitious, I didn't have a strong will to win," the India No.1 said. That changed towards 2024-25. In January 2025, the world No.8 won his first major tournament, the Tata Steel Chess Tour-



R Praggnanandhaa

nament, defeating then newly crowned world champion Gukesh in the playoff. "It's something I had to learn. I had to build that mindset. Now it's becoming easier. I can push myself." →

MY INDIA | 3-DAY VISIT

Jaishankar to visit Ukraine, Poland



External affairs minister S. Jaishankar will undertake a three-day visit to Ukraine and Poland beginning Thursday amid escalating hostilities between Moscow and Kyiv. In Kyiv, Jaishankar is expected to press for finding a peaceful resolution to the Russia-Ukraine conflict. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar will undertake an official visit to Ukraine and the Republic of Poland from September 3 to 5, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said. It said he will hold bilateral consultations with his Ukrainian counterpart Andriy Sydya and Polish Deputy Prime Minister Radoslaw Sikorski. "The visit will focus on enhancing bilateral relations and also provide an opportunity to exchange views on regional developments and issues of mutual interest," the MEA said in a statement. India has been consistently calling for ending the Russia-Ukraine conflict through dialogue and diplomacy.

BUSINESS | UNITED STATES

Google defeats bid to force ad tech sale



Alphabet's Google escaped a breakup of its advertising technology business on Wednesday, when a judge in Virginia rejected US antitrust enforcers' bid to force a sale of Google's online advertising exchange. While the ad exchange is a small part of Google's business, the ruling is the second powerful symbolic victory against the US Department of Justice in its efforts to force Google to split assets to address illegal monopolies. The judge declined to make Google sell AdX, where publishers pay Google a 20% fee to sell ads in auctions that happen instantly when users load websites. She accepted most of the parties' proposed behavioral remedies. The DOJ and a broad coalition of states sued Google in 2023 over its dominance in markets for advertising technology.

SPORT | IN JAPAN

Sports min approves 246 coaches, officials for Asiad



The sports ministry on Wednesday cleared the names of 246 coaches and support staff members to accompany Indian athletes at the upcoming Asian Games that begin in Japan's Aichi-Nagoya on Sept 19. The number of athletes has also been increased from 492 (265 men and 227 women) to 593 (269 male & 234 female) following the addition of the four-member surfing team, six athletes and one Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) athlete. The total strength of the Indian contingent now stands at 768. Praveen Kumar (Hammer throw), Harita Bhadra (200m), Kiran Pahal (400m), Asha Ilango (triple jump), Sindhu Shree Ganesh (pole vault), Sanya Yadav (discus throw) are the additions to the athletics team while Varun Sanyal has been added to the MMA team in the Traditional 77kg event. The surfing team comprises Kishore Kumar Anbarasu, Sivara Babu, Kamali Prakash, and Sugar Shanti Gayen in shortboard.

BUSINESS | IN FISCAL YEAR 2027

Apple to pay \$58mn to new CEO Ternus



Apple said new chief executive officer John Ternus will get a compensation package worth about \$58 million in fiscal 2027, while Tim Cook's role as executive chairman will pay around \$47 million. The company made the disclosure in a filing with the Securities and Exchange Commission on Tuesday, the first day of Ternus's tenure. The new CEO will be paid a \$3 million annual base salary moving forward and receive a stock grant with a target value of \$55 million next year. Cook, 65, is handing the reins to Ternus after a 15-year tenure that saw the company expand into new products and boost its annual revenue to nearly half a trillion dollars. The 51-year-old Ternus will receive a prorated amount of restricted stock units worth about \$2.5 million in fiscal 2026, which runs through September.

BUSINESS | 'FOR FASTER OPS'

Uber to lay off 10% of global workforce



Ride-hailing giant Uber will be laying off around 10% of its staff as part of 'significant organizational changes', CEO Dara Khosrowshahi said in a message to employees released on Wednesday. "Today, we're making a number of significant organizational changes across Uber," Khosrowshahi said. "As a result, we will be reducing the size of our team by about 10%." Uber has roughly 34,000 employees with operations in over 70 countries, according to a recent SEC filing. The company said the layoffs were aimed at making the platform "simpler and faster" and at reducing coordination delays. Founded in 2009, Uber remade the urban transportation sector by disrupting markets dominated by taxi and private car companies, allowing people to use their own vehicles to give others rides. On Wednesday, Uber said it was shutting down its business in Nigeria and Uganda.

Online-offline gap leaves out voters in SR

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NEW DELHI: "We did everything by the book," said 31-year-old Lokesh Kumar, a resident of Jangpura in south-east Delhi, as he tried to make sense of why his name, along with those of three other family members, was missing from Delhi's draft special intensive review (SIR) released earlier this week. They filled the enumeration forms online via the Election Commission's (EC's) portal or the ECNET app, expecting a routine update to their voter roll records. And yet, when the draft electoral roll was published on Monday, their names were missing.

Their experience is mirrored in neighbourhoods across the Capital. HT spoke to dozens of people from Badarpur, Trikolpur, Mangolpuri, and other constituencies who said they submitted their enumeration forms online, but were left off the rolls. Badarpur, Trikolpur and Mangolpuri recorded deletions of 42.67%, 35%, and 21.2%, respectively.

Lokesh got his voter ID at 19. "I make it a point to vote each time. I first voted in the 2015 Delhi assembly elections, then in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls and the 2025 assembly elections as well. I couldn't vote in 2020 due to the health emergency. Finding my name missing from the list was shocking," he said.

Both level officers (BLOs), electoral registration officers (EROs), and political workers attribute this phenomenon to a misunderstanding of the process.

Anish Kumar Jha, a BLO in Jangpura, said, "Many people think that the online process ends with form submission and then don't bother reaching out to the BLO. When a form is submitted online, it is not automatically added to the roll. A BLO still needs to verify the submission via a phone call or a physical visit."

For this process, a BLO needs to call the number linked with the online application. In several cases, this number does not match the one linked to the voter's Aadhaar or existing voter ID, leading to what officers call a "technical mismatch."

"Once we figure out that the number used to fill the form does not match the one linked with Aadhaar or voter ID, we are supposed to reject the form and tell the voter to re-register. When the correction window opens later," he added.

Lokesh and his family, however, were not informed that their forms had been rejected.

An ERO from the area explained, "BLOs usually don't understand which category to place these voters under. Unreturned online forms cannot be shifted into the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate (ASDD) category which is meant for those who never responded at all. Others place them into the 'enumeration form not returned' category. This means they're dropped from the roll altogether."

On Monday, EC published the draft electoral roll for Delhi, dropping nearly 4.76 million or 32.8% names—marking the deletion of more male names than women and the highest proportion

SUMMERTIME MADNESS

PL shells out billions on transfers

European clubs spent billions bolstering their squads in the summer transfer window, which shut early on Wednesday. The Premier League itself spent more than the others combined, turning the focus on not just inflated transfer valuations, but also the deep pockets of the English clubs

\$4.69 billion

PL clubs smashed the transfer spending record. The previous record of \$4.30bn was set in the previous summer window

How the major European leagues spent

LEAGUE	SPENT (€ mn)
Serie A	841
LaLiga	602
Bundesliga	506
Ligue 1	489

Premier League's biggest spenders

LEAGUE	SPENT (€ MN)
Man City	457
Chelsea	348
Tottenham	312
Newcastle	267
Aston Villa	255

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NEW DELHI: Dark matter is called dark because it cannot be seen. Scientists believe it must be there because nothing else adequately explains many of the things we observe in the universe. But no one has detected dark matter itself, far less seen it.

Until now—or maybe not. In an experiment a mile underground in a South Dakota research facility, scientists have detected signs of what may have been an interaction between ordinary matter and a dark-matter particle. They are cautious about committing themselves: it is a single event, and does not prove conclusively that dark matter was involved.

The uncertainty aside, the findings are exciting. The researchers believe this may be the first hint of a direct detection, if it is that. Until now, evidence for dark matter has come from observing its apparent gravitational effects—how galaxies, stars and other structures in the universe behave.

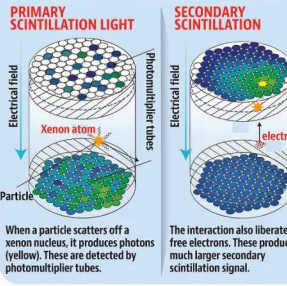
What is dark matter? Scientists have believed in the existence of dark matter for almost a century now. The concept was first proposed in 1933 by Swiss astronomer Fritz Zwicky. Studying a galaxy cluster, he observed that the individual galaxies were moving at speeds that could not be explained by visible mass. Hence, he proposed, some "dark matter" must account for the missing mass and its gravitational effects.

Over the decades, the idea became mainstream as scientists tried various other observations to the likely presence of dark matter. There is gravitational lensing, for instance: when astronomers measure the bending of light in galaxy clusters, the results point to a mass that is much higher than the mass of the visible matter. Other observations that cannot be explained by ordinary matter include the pattern of tiny temperature fluctuations in the early universe, and the way galaxies and clusters have formed and are distributed.

"Dark matter has been a longstanding puzzle—either we don't understand gravity on distances beyond the solar system or there's missing stuff. In our galaxy, you need some additional source of matter to explain the orbiting speed of the stars. We can't see this matter but we see the effects of it. This is what we call dark matter," particle physicist Sam Eriksen of the University of Bristol told HT. He is the lead author of a study describing the findings of the recent experiment.

Hunting Dark Matter's signature

The LZ experiment's detector device is a large cylindrical vessel containing 10 tonnes of liquid xenon. If a dark matter particle strikes a xenon atom, it can produce telltale flashes of light.



Today, ordinary matter—everything that we see—is believed to represent only about 15% of all matter. Everything else is believed to be dark matter. But it does not emit or reflect light, and is invisible to us.

If you cannot see it, the only way to detect dark matter is to look for signals it leaves on visible matter. That is what the recent experiment sought to find, and possibly did.

particles. "There are many hypothesised dark matter particles, WIMPs, axions, etc. But none have been observed. The LZ experiment primarily searches for WIMPs, and in the latest work, we observed a single event which appears how we'd expect a WIMP to," Eriksen said.

The detector is a large cylindrical vessel containing 10 tonnes of liquid xenon. The element in its liquid form is dense, providing several advantages for such experiments: "We use xenon because it's incredibly dense so there's a higher probability for dark matter to hit an atom, so, we only expect very few occurrences a year, or less," said Eriksen, whose paper has been submitted to the journal Physical Review Letters.

"When any particle interacts with the xenon, we see flashes of light. In fact, we see two flashes of light," he said. First, the interaction produces immediate photons—particles of light—at the interaction site. The interaction also liberates free electrons, which produce a much larger secondary signal.

"The properties of these flashes allow us to determine what kind of particle collided with the xenon as well as the energy and position of the interaction. WIMPs are expected to be very distinct from other particles. What we've seen is an interaction that doesn't look like any back-

ground," Eriksen said. The researchers described the detection in an announcement at a scientific conference in Japan on Tuesday. "We can't draw definitive conclusions and we can't rule out that this isn't some rare process that looks the same. But it could be the first hint of a dark matter observation," Eriksen said.

Not yet a discovery Although the interaction appeared to indicate the involvement of a WIMP, the researchers do not claim the actual detection of dark matter. The observation does not meet the statistical threshold necessary to make such a claim.

"Importantly, as it's just a single event, we are not claiming that it is dark matter," Eriksen said. "We considered many different things that could have caused this event, including neutrinos, neutrons and unique gamma-ray interactions. However, none of these can explain the event we've observed," he said. "There could still be processes that result in WIMP-like signals, and we're putting this result out to get feedback from the scientific community. Ultimately, it's a single event, and we'll only be able to confirm this observation with more data, which will hopefully contain more events," he said. The researchers are working to rule out other explanations.

Govt's ₹28.5-cr cloud seeding pays ruins into weather hurdle

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BENGALURU: Meteorologists and senior officials have cast doubts on the veracity of the government's plan to kickstart cloud seeding operations around the end of September at a cost of ₹28.5 crore to balance out the state's rainfall deficit. Experts cited prevailing meteorological conditions to recommend the exercise's deferment to October's second week, arguing that the atmosphere currently lacks the clouds and moisture needed for the operation.

A senior official from the Karnataka State Natural Disaster Monitoring Centre (KSNDMC),

who attended a meeting on the proposed operations on Monday, said the state would first have to identify clouds suitable for seeding. There are currently few such formations, the official said, while forecasts for the next few weeks do not indicate conditions favourable for the exercise.

Cloud seeding can enhance precipitation from an existing cloud but cannot manufacture a rain bearing system in a clear sky. The process also depends on moisture within clouds, super-cooled water droplets, wind direction and humidity.

For the operation to have a reasonable chance of producing rain, the IMD has said there must be sufficiently developed

OFFICIALS AND EXPERTS ARGUED THAT THE CLOUD SEEDING EXERCISE BE DEFERRED TO OCTOBER'S SECOND WEEK

cumulus or cumulonimbus clouds, favourable winds and a low pressure area or offshore trough over the sea. Atmospheric moisture between the surface and the clouds must also be at least 55 to 60 mm.

Those requirements are currently not being met. The state is nevertheless mov-

ing ahead with preparations. Deputy chief minister G Parameshwara on Tuesday said the technical team had begun preparations after the government issued orders for the exercise. "We have to see how effective it will be. According to the technical assessment, it may not result in heavy rainfall, but could bring light showers. The experts have said that even such rainfall could help the crops. Based on this, we have agreed to go ahead with the exercise," he said.

The government's decision comes against a backdrop of rainfall shortages across Karnataka. KSNDMC has identified 178 taluks in 27 districts as facing drought conditions. The techni-

cal assessment was discussed at a meeting attended by representatives of the IMD, KSNDMC, Indian Institute of Science, Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology, Karnataka Irrigation Corporation Limited, water resources department and rural development and panchayat raj department. Retired experts and meteorologists also took part.

An IMD official said the systems over the Arabian Sea were weaker than those over the Bay of Bengal. A monsoon depression near the Western Ghats has been supporting rainfall over coastal and north Karnataka, while interior and southern parts of the state continue to receive deficient rainfall.



Priyank Kharge
PRIYANK: WILL SET UP INNOVATION CENTRE FOR MODERN POLICING

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BENGALURU: State home minister Priyank Kharge on Wednesday said the home department will set up an 'innovation centre' to make Karnataka's police system more modern and future-ready, in line with the needs of rapidly growing cities.

He said the centre will not focus solely on cybersecurity but will function as a comprehensive platform to leverage technology, data and innovative ideas across all major areas of policing.

According to a statement from the minister's office, developing technology-based solutions for crime prevention, investigation, traffic and mobility management, intelligence analysis, efficient deployment of police resources, urban planning and civic services will be among the centre's key objectives.

"Police systems must evolve at the same pace as cities. We cannot apply today's policing systems to the cities of the future. Our objective is to effectively use technology and data to equip the police department with the ability to identify and address problems proactively, rather than merely responding after they occur," Priyank said.



State BJP president BY Vijayendra leads the padayatra at Maski in Raichur district on Wednesday.

CM: Padayatra bid to fix BJP's internal crisis

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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Wednesday dismissed the BJP's 10-day 'Ballari Chalo' padayatra as an effort to deal with problems within the party, while accusing the opposition of having links to alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission.

"(The padayatra) is an attempt to overcome the internal crisis within the BJP," Shivakumar told reporters near the KFCI office in Bengaluru.

The march ended its second day on Wednesday, with state president BY Vijayendra leading party leaders, legislators and workers from Sankellur in Maski. The day's route was expected to cover about 22 km. The route is to pass through Maski, Sindhanur, Karatagi, Gangavathi, Kampli, Sandur and Ballari Rural constituencies before ending in Ballari city.

Shivakumar said the government had received information about the alleged involvement of BJP leaders in the KPSC case and that the material had been given to the home minister and officials. He said the government had not yet received the full investigation report. "At present, we are aware only of the information that has appeared in the media," he said.

He said the probe should examine the appointment of the KPSC chairman and his contacts with BJP leaders. "The information available with the home minister regarding the BJP and NDA's connection with the KPSC exams will be disclosed at the appropriate time," he said.

Shivakumar also pointed to the appointment of the KPSC chairman as an issue requiring examination. "The KPSC Chairman was appointed by the BJP. There should also be an inquiry into who was in contact with him. Union minister Pralhad Joshi

himself had earlier written a letter seeking his suspension," he said.

The chief minister also said the commissions had become the Government's report and matters connected to the investigation.

The BJP's march began in Lingasur on Tuesday and is planned to cover about 185 km before ending in Ballari. The party says it is protesting alleged corruption and failures of the Congress government, including the diversion of funds intended for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, inadequate drought relief and the alleged neglect of North Karnataka.

Addressing reporters on Wednesday, Vijayendra alleged that corruption and demands for commissions had become entrenched in the Congress government. He cited allegations that engineers of the Karnataka Rural Infrastructure Development Limited's Mangaluru division had demanded a 7% commission from contractors executing various projects under the state government's undertaking. Vijayendra said the issue demonstrated the "level to which the administration has fallen".

BJP leaders on Wednesday did not offer responses to Shivakumar's allegations. On the BJP's campaign, he said the Congress would respond in its own way. "Let them undertake their padayatra. I will not disclose what our yatra is for at this stage. We will not sit still," (with PTI inputs)

5 students injured after section of classroom ceiling falls at govt school

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BELAGAVI: Five students were injured on Wednesday after a section of a classroom ceiling collapsed during lessons at a government school in Bagalkot district, officials said.

The students from Classes 5 and 6 were taken to a hospital in a vehicle owned by the block education officer, and discharged later in the evening. One student sustained a head injury, while others suffered minor abrasions, said officials.

Deputy director of public instruction Sitaram RS, who visited the school, said the incident took place at about 1 pm. The affected classroom was being used by 26 students, including 10 from Class 5 and 12 from Class 6.

Parents said the school building had remained in poor condition for years and that the



The damaged section of the classroom ceiling at the school in Bagalkot district on Wednesday.

concrete ceiling had deteriorated to the point where reinforcement rods were visible. They said teachers had previously been informed about the condition of the building. They said authorities should assess the structure immediately, prevent children from using unsafe rooms and arrange

alternative classrooms until repairs or replacement work is completed.

Sitaram said the building had already been examined by an engineer during the summer vacation last year. "The engineer had submitted a report stating that all the classrooms were safe," he said.

City to host 16th Aero India from Feb 8-12

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NEW DELHI: India's biennial aerospace exhibition Aero India will be held at Yelahanka on the outskirts of Bengaluru from February 8-12 with an aim to project the country as a hub for defence manufacturing.

Aero India has emerged as a flagship international event showcasing the nation's growing capabilities in aerospace, defence manufacturing, emerging technologies and innovation.

"Aero India, Asia's largest air show and one of the world's premier aerospace and defence exhibitions, is all set to return to the city with its 16th edition at Air Force Station, Yelahanka in Bengaluru from February 8 to 12, 2027," the defence ministry announced on Wednesday.

The ministry's statement said the event will bring together leading global aerospace and defence companies, policymakers, technology experts, innovators, industry stakeholders and defence forces personnel.

Stir for revised minimum wage



All India United Trade Union Congress (AIUTUC) stage a protest for the implementation of the revised minimum wage notification at Freedom Park in Bengaluru on Wednesday.

7.5 km-Pink Line stretch to open soon: Minister

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BENGALURU: Bengaluru development minister Krishna Byre Gowda on Wednesday said the 7.5-km stretch of Bengaluru's Pink Line would soon be opened to the public.

Gowda, along with BJP MP Tejashwari Surya, MLA M Krishnappa, Metro MD P C Jafar and officials, undertook a trial run from Jayadeva Station to Kalena Agrahara and reviewed the progress ahead of the line's opening.

"The 7.5-km Kalena Agrahara-Tavarekere stretch of Bengaluru's Pink Line is ready for inauguration and will soon be

open to the public. We are hopeful of receiving an inauguration date from the Government of India in September," the Greater Bengaluru development minister said in a post on X.

BJP MP Surya said Bangalore

Commissioner of Metro Railway Safety officials on the safety clearances and timelines. Rolling stock approval is expected within the next 15 days, followed by clearances for the entire line. I will work closely with officials and the Central Government to ensure these approvals are secured at the earliest," he said in a post on X.

The MP said the Pink Line would significantly ease congestion on Bannerghatta Road and strengthen Bengaluru's mass transit network. "Bengaluru needs more public transport projects like this, scientific, sustainable and designed to ease traffic, instead of stupid ideas like the Tunnel Road," he said.

Metrol Rail Corporation Limited had targeted the line's inauguration by the end of this month, adding that he and the minister had urged officials to adhere to the deadline.

"This morning, I spoke to

APPROVER'S STATEMENT IN RENUKASWAMY CASE DEFERRED

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BENGALURU: A Bengaluru court on Wednesday deferred the recording of the statement of the 14th accused in the Renukaswamy murder case as the prosecution sought time to file a separate petition linked to the case. The 55th City Civil and Sessions Court was scheduled to record Pradosh's statement as part of the process to consider him as a pardon witness. Special Public Prosecutor Prasanna Kumar asked the court to postpone the proceedings, saying the high court had not yet passed its order in the matter.

The request and fixed Monday for recording Pradosh's statement. Pradosh was brought to the court from the prison authorities. He completed the required procedures and signed the documents before being taken back to jail after the hearing was adjourned.

The high court matter concerns a separate petition filed by two accused in the Renukaswamy case. They have sought to withdraw from the FIR registered at Kamakshihalli police station and proceedings arising from allegations of intimidation of witnesses.

A bench of justice M Nagaprasanna heard the petition on Wednesday. The petition was filed by M. Subhas, 33, of Amruthnagar in Tumakuru, and R.G. Venu of Upparahalli.

After hearing senior advocate Harman Pasha, who appeared for the petitioners, and the prosecution, HC reserved its order.

College student abducted, beaten in Bengaluru

BENGALURU: A college student was allegedly abducted and assaulted by a group, police said on Wednesday. The incident occurred at around 12.10 pm on Tuesday when the student was parking his car near this college back gate, they said, adding that the motive is under investigation. The 19-year-old student alleged that the accused forced him into a white car and drove away before beating him severely, injuring his face, head, neck and chest.

Raj teases as city IPS officer to dupe people, held Bengaluru: A juvenile from Rajasthan was apprehended for allegedly creating a fake Facebook account in the name of an IPS officer and collecting money from people, police said on Wednesday.

The accused created a fake account in the name of IPS officer Narayana M, who is currently posted as DCP (Electronic City Division) in Bengaluru, they said. Police recovered ₹2 lakh in cash from the juvenile, which was allegedly part of the proceeds.

PT teacher injured after being struck by discus at event SHIVAMOGGA: A physical education teacher was seriously injured after being accidentally hit on the head by a discus during a zonal-level school sports meet in Shivamogga district, officials said.

The incident took place at Chinnu Gowda Stadium in Rippinpete town of Hosanagara taluk during a sports meet organised for students under the age of 17. The injured man was identified as Kamalakara, a teacher at Mary Mata School.

Kargil war veteran attempts suicide over land allotment delay

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CHIKKABALLAPURA: A Kargil war veteran allegedly attempted suicide after prolonged delay over longstanding delay in allotting land despite pursuing the matter for over two decades, police said on Wednesday.

The incident was reported on August 28 in the premises of Inspection Bungalow in Chintamani taluk, they said. Officials said the veteran, who was injured while serving in the war, allegedly consumed pesticide out of frustration over the prolonged delay in allotting him land reportedly recommended for him in recognition of his military service.

He is under treatment at a hospital in Bengaluru. His statement is yet to be recorded as doctors have not yet declared him fit to give a statement, a senior officer said.

In his letter addressed to Chintamani Tahsildar earlier this year, the ex-serviceman had sought allotment of two hectares of land, alleging that authorities had failed to provide him land despite his request pending for 26 years.

HE IS UNDER TREATMENT AND HIS STATEMENT IS YET TO BE RECORDED AS DOCTORS HAVE NOT YET DECLARED HIM FIT, SAID SENIOR OFFICER

"Was it not possible to identify land for a disabled ex-serviceman who has been seeking it for 26 years," he asked in the letter.

He said he had served in the Indian Army and questioned whether it was his mistake to have served the country.

He urged the Tahsildar to allot the suitable land that had already been identified for him. In the letter, he also warned that the authorities would be responsible for any "untoward incidents" that may occur if his demand was not addressed.

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9315767849

{ MEKEDATU RESERVOIR PROJECT }

Min meets CWC chief to seek technical nod

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NEW DELHI/BENGALURU: Karnataka has stepped up its efforts to advance the Mekedatu Balancing Reservoir Project across Cauvery river. State water resources minister N Chaluvaraswamy met Central Water Commission (CWC) Chairman Anupam Prasad in New Delhi on Wednesday to discuss technical approvals required for the project.

The meeting also covered the comprehensive compliance report by the Karnataka government in response to observations and technical issues earlier raised by the CWC on the project's Detailed Project Report (DPR).

Chaluvaraswamy urged the CWC to facilitate the timely examination of the project and



N Chaluvaraswamy

extend the necessary technical cooperation, his office said.

He also assured the commission that the water resources department would promptly provide any additional technical information or clarifications required during examination.

The discussions assume significance following the recent inspection of the Mekedatu Project by CWC member Jogesh Patankar. The state delegation shared details of the

ground conditions at the proposed project site.

The minister underlined the growing importance of Mekedatu in addressing Bengaluru's long-term drinking water requirements, particularly against the backdrop of increasing water demand and rainfall variability.

The proposed balancing reservoir is envisaged to support the drinking water needs of Bengaluru and neighbouring districts, facilitate hydropower generation and improve the management and regulated release of water downstream.

Chaluvaraswamy also highlighted the potential importance of the project during years of rainfall deficit, stating that improved water storage and regulation would help strengthen water management while facilitating the regulated

release of water downstream in accordance with applicable requirements.

The state government reiterated its strong commitment to taking the project forward and requested CWC to complete the ongoing technical examination at the earliest, in accordance with established procedures, the release said.

The delegation included Gaurav Gupta, Additional Chief Secretary, Water Resources Department, Krishnamurthy Kulkarni, the Department's Secretary, and other officials.

Mekedatu is a multi-purpose project (drinking water and power) which involves building a balancing reservoir near Kanakapura in Bengaluru South district. Tamil Nadu opposes the project, citing its potential affect on downstream riparian states along the river system.

Woman drowns twins, attempts suicide, held

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BENGALURU: A 43-year-old woman was arrested after her four-month-old twin daughters were found dead at their home in Thalaghattapura on Tuesday in a suspected murder-suicide attempt, police said on Wednesday.

Officers alleged that her husband returned home around 3 pm and found her allegedly attempting suicide while the children lay dead in the same room.

Inspector Ramachandra Chaudhary said the initial investigation indicated that the woman had drowned the children before attempting suicide. "By that time, her husband reached home, noticed what had happened and rescued her,"

Chaudhary said.

Their bodies were sent to Kempegowda Institute of Medical Sciences for postmortem examination. NIMHANS reportedly said that the autopsy will establish the cause of death. The couple reportedly remained childless for nearly two decades before undergoing IVF treatment, said police.

Her husband alleged that doctors at a hospital in Raghunathnagar and NIMHANS reportedly told the family that the woman could suffer from postpartum depression and hormonal imbalance after childbirth.

The woman is being treated at NIMHANS and is out of danger. We have registered a case under Section 103 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and launched a probe," Chaudhary said.

Color strategists head to Ayodhya

‘Need to learn lessons from past, but do not let past burden us’

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NEW DELHI: Air Marshal (ret.) Jeetendra Mishra, the first chief executive officer (CEO) of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, was one of the top planners of Operation Sindoore and received a medal for distinguished service of exceptional order for his role during the four-day military confrontation with Pakistan last year.

Mishra, a fighter combat leader and an experimental test pilot, retired on April 30 as the Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Subroto Park-based Western Air Command. Air Marshal Mishra has more than 3,000 hours of flying experience.

The Command was at the centre of operational activities during Operation Sindoore—New Delhi's muscular response to the Pakistan-backed Palaham terror attack that killed 26 people. It triggered four days of strikes and counterstrikes with fighter jets, missiles, drones, long-range weapons and heavy artillery between the two sides reaping an understanding on stopping all military action on May 10, 2025.

Under Mishra's leadership, the WAC was ready to strike targets in Pakistan within hours of the Pakistan attack. He was instrumental in selecting the terror targets in Pakistan and determining the weapons best suited to hit them with minimal collateral damage, people aware of the matter said. Mishra was awarded the Sarvottam Yudh Seva Medal for his role. "He is known for applying himself to the assigned task and executing it well," said one of his NDA course-mates.

Mishra accompanied Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the Adityanagar base in Punjab after Operation Sindoore. The visit was designed to puncture Pakistan's extensive disinformation campaign against India. In a career spanning more than four decades, Mishra held several commands and held appointments, including commanding officer of a fighter squadron, chief test pilot at Patiala College, Systems Testing Establishment (ASTE), Air Officer Commanding of two frontline air bases, Director (Operational Planning and Assessment Group) and Assistant Chief of Staff (Projects) at Air HQ, Commandant ASTE and Deputy Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Doctrine, Organisation and Training).

BIHAR'S NEEDS TO BE CONSIDERED IN FARAKKA TREATY DECISION: EAM

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NEW DELHI: The external affairs ministry has said that any decision on the Ganga Water Treaty, also known as the Farakka Treaty, will be taken keeping in mind the drinking water needs of the people, said people aware of the details. The assurance comes in the wake of the Janata Dal (United), an ally of the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA), demanding that the government should not renew the treaty that was signed in 1996 between India and Bangladesh over the sharing of Ganga water.

In response to the demand put forth by Sanjay Jha, Rajya Sabha MP and the national working president of the JD(U), External affairs minister S Jaishankar has said the decision on the renewal of the treaty will be taken after considering the state's potable and industrial needs.

Jha had made a Special Mention of the issue in Parliament during the last monsoon session, pointing out how the treaty's adverse impacts Bihar. He said the treaty, which expires on December 12, had adversely affected Bihar's drinking water supply. He also pointed out that the treaty, which expires on December 12, had adversely affected Bihar's drinking water supply. He also pointed out that the treaty, which expires on December 12, had adversely affected Bihar's drinking water supply.

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NEW DELHI: Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (ret.), the first chief executive officer of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, on Wednesday said his four decades of service in the Indian Air Force would serve him well in his new role. In an interview with HT, Mishra also said he looked forward to taking on the challenges and responsibilities along with team spirit as his guiding principle. Edited excerpts:

What are your thoughts right now?
I am full of gratitude, and I consider myself a very fortunate person because from the age of 17 years till 60 years, I got the opportunity to serve the nation in the Indian Air Force. I include the time spent in the National Defence Academy. That's 43 years in uniform. And a few months after I retired, I got this opportunity to serve the Shri Ram Temple and the Ram bhaktas. I think there cannot be anybody more fortunate than me.

What was the reason you applied for the CEO's job? What was the goal? Thought of people applied for this position.
I applied for the same reasons that those thousands applied. To serve the nation. Lord Ram does

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JAIPUR: The dilapidated building of a government school in Jaipur's Rampura Kanwarpara village was demolished on Wednesday for the construction of a new building, about two years after the school was inaugurated. The school had been functioning from a buffalo shed. "During the inspection, stones were thrown at us, women were assaulted and cat-dogs were broken. But when a good school is built for our children, it will be worth it," Ranka wrote on X.

The BJP, however, disputed the CJP's claim of credit. Party spokesperson Lakshmi Kant Bhardwaj, in a post on X, said funds for the project had been sanctioned before the CJP took office. "We care about nothing for farmers."

He further asked the district chiefs to stop chasing leaders and instead reach out to people, build direct connections with them and understand their concerns. "Political ambition is a good thing, but it should be realised only by working among the people and strengthening the party at the grassroots," he said. He added that the US had built its global power on the strength of the dollar and its military. India, he said, needed to develop similar economic and strategic capabilities. The US had focused on production, which generated employment, while India had increasingly moved towards trading, he said.

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NEW DELHI: The BJP leadership is keen to reset the political narrative to keep the spotlight on issues such as the government's "development model" and "accomplishments in the economic and other sectors" to avert being caught in a bind between pro-reservation and anti-reservation groups exerting pressure on the government to meet their demands, said people aware of the details.

The BJP has successfully used social engineering to give representation to various castes and communities, particularly socially marginalised groups. However, several party leaders said the so-called upper castes (UCs), a core BJP votebank, are showing signs of disenchantment over issues including political representation and are



Air Marshal (ret.) Jeetendra Mishra

do not require my service. It's the nation and the people who require my service.

What will be your strategy going forward?
I would like to say that I cannot make a strategy on my own. It has to be under the guidance of the Trust and along with my team, the rest of the team. You know, my strategy will become infructuous if I do not take the team along or do not take the guidance of the Trust. It won't progress.

So team spirit will be the guiding principle?
Yes, absolutely. Also, managerial processes are fundamentally the same everywhere; they simply need to be tailored to the task at hand. I'll put in my best effort. The success is dependent on so many other factors.

Your thoughts on the

alleged donation theft?
We need to learn lessons from the past, but do not let the past burden us. We've been running this organisation very well, and will probably join the team and do my bit to make it a little better. That's all.

How will your IAF background help you?
The qualitative requirements for the CEO, which the other applicants also would have had, are almost similar. It's a question of discipline, hard work, integrity, and integrity, which is what the search committee based its search upon.

Any thoughts on your role during Operation Sindoore?
I would only say that I was fortunate to be available at the time when my nation needed it, and I was able to succeed. For that, I not only thank the Almighty, but I also thank the citizens of nation, my team here in Western Air Command and the Indian Air Force, and all of you all, the media. It's always a team effort.

How do you plan to celebrate?
Currently, I'm unable to get off my phone. The moment I get off the phone, my mother is waiting. I have to take her aashirwad also. She's been waiting for the last two hours.

Meanwhile, Bhagchandka, a close associate to one of the stalwarts of Ram Janmabhoomi movement, Ashok Singhal, will also take over the charge from Giri as the new trustee.

With the development, curia will fall on Chhatrapati Raj's return. Rai had resigned on June 26 after the donation theft row. The decisions came during a crucial meeting of the trust's executive committee, which was held in Ayodhya.

"Out of three names shortlisted by the search committee, the trust selected former Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra for the CEO's post," said Krishna

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MUMBAI: Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday said India has neglected farming despite its potential to make the country a superpower. "We are doing an excessive focus on trading rather than production had limited job opportunities."

Addressing 98 newly appointed Congress district and city presidents at the concluding ceremony of a 10-day residential training camp in Nagpur, Gandhi said, "We care about nothing for farmers."

He further asked the district chiefs to stop chasing leaders and instead reach out to people, build direct connections with them and understand their concerns. "Political ambition is a good thing, but it should be realised only by working among the people and strengthening the party at the grassroots," he said. He added that the US had built its global power on the strength of the dollar and its military. India, he said, needed to develop similar economic and strategic capabilities. The US had focused on production, which generated employment, while India had increasingly moved towards trading, he said.

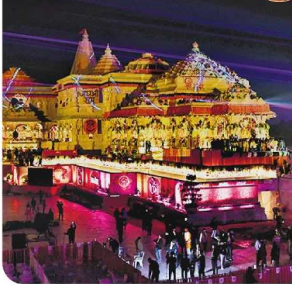
Party seeks to reset political narrative with spotlight on development model, economy

The three new trustees

MAHESH BHAGCHANDKA, DELHI-BASED BUSINESSMAN: The founder chairman of the MZK Group conglomerate, Bhagchandka will take over charge from Govind Dev Giri, who was the trust's treasurer since its formation. He is related to former VHP president Ashok Singhal and will now handle the multi-crore finances of the Ram Temple.

MADAN MOHAN PANDEY, FORMER UP ADDITIONAL ADVOCATE GENERAL: The 74-year-old Ayodhya-based advocate worked her nomination sparked celebration in Firabad and her maternal home at Awagarh, Etah. Currently, she is vice-president of Rashtriya Shaikshik Mahasangh.

NIRMALA YADAV, SHIKHABAD ACADEMICIAN: A long-time Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) worker, her nomination sparked celebration in Firabad and her maternal home at Awagarh, Etah. Currently, she is vice-president of Rashtriya Shaikshik Mahasangh.



Mishra's appointment as CEO for three years marks a shift from trustee-led management to professional corporate oversight for daily security, logistics, crowd and multi-crore funds. The temple trust has been grappling the allegations of donation theft since it first surfaced on June 7, when Samji-

wadi Party (SP) leader Tej Narayan 'Pawan' Pandey alleged that the trust had misappropriated ₹5 crore to ₹7.5 crore funds siphoned off from temple offerings.

On June 13, the state government set up the first SIT and a probe began.

RAHUL'S INDORE EVENT POSTPONED
INDORE: The Congress on Wednesday said that party leader Rahul Gandhi's Chhatron Ki Goonj event in Madhya Pradesh's Indore, earlier planned to be held on September 12, has been postponed to September 19 due to the state government's denial of permission to use a city-based stadium as the programme venue.

State Congress president Jitendra Pawar made this announcement during a meeting held to take stock of the preparations for the event. He said the government denied permission to hold the event at the Jawahar Nehru Stadium, due to which the event will now be held on September 19 instead of September 12. The party will now find a new venue for the event and make preparations accordingly.

Saubhadra Chatterjee and Sanjay Maurya
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NEW DELHI: A Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) will resume discussions on the controversial Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, after a gap of more than a month, with the panel set to hear views of experts from Himachal Pradesh on September 11.

The move comes after the committee's draft report on the legislation was not adopted during the monsoon session as lawmakers across party lines sought further discussions on the Bill.

HC considers CBI probe in death of Disha Saian

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MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday ordered the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to register an FIR and conduct a fresh investigation into the death of celebrity manager Disha Saian, observing that the inquiry carried out by the police was "inadequate and raised more questions than it answered."

A division bench of justice Santosh V Kulkarni and justice Ranjishtha Bhonsale directed the CBI to appoint an experienced officer as an Investigating Officer in the case and register an FIR based on the statement of Disha's father, Satish Saian.

The court also clarified that "nobody shall be treated as an accused unless, in the opinion of the IO, there are sufficient grounds to raise reasonable suspicion against them."

The directions came on a petition filed by Satish Saian, seeking an independent probe into the death of his 28-year-old daughter, Disha, who briefly worked with actor Sushant Singh Rajput, died while falling from the 12th floor of a building in Malad on June 8, 2020. The Malvani police inquired into the incident and closed the inquiry after finding no foul play in her death and recording that her parents did not harbour any suspicion.

Last year, however, Satish Saian approached the high court claiming that his daughter was sexually assaulted and murdered. His lawyer, advocate Nilesh Ojha, argued that the death was the outcome of a "deep rooted conspiracy involving powerful people" and she was subject to brutal sexual

assault and murdered. Saian's lawyer further claimed that the death of his daughter and that of Sushant Singh Rajput were interlinked and though the police conducted an investigation and submitted their report to the assistant commissioner of police on February 4, 2021, its copy was neither submitted to a magistrate court, nor were given to Disha's family members. Subsequently, the investigation was reopened and a special investigation team (SIT) was formed to probe the matter in December 2023.

"This case deserves registration of FIR and substantive investigation in a cognizable offence," the court said, adding that though "the police have neither registered an FIR, nor have they carried out the investigation of a cognizable offence. Instead, they conducted an investigation under the provisions of section 174 of CrPc, which according to us, was inadequate and insufficient," the court remarked while ordering a CBI probe into the incident.

Disha's father Satish Saian welcomed the court's judgement. "This case has been pending for over two years. We have struggled a lot and will have to continue struggling; otherwise, I will not be able to get justice for my daughter."

{ ₹504-CR IDFC BANK FRAUD }
6 IAS officers named in CBI's charge sheet

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PANCHKULA: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Wednesday named six IAS officers in its third charge sheet filed in connection with the ₹504-crore IDFC Bank fraud involving multiple Haryana government departments and organisations, officials said.

In the charge sheet, named before the special CBI court, the federal agency has named Pardeep Kumar, then member secretary, Haryana state pollution control board (HSPCB); Ram Kumar Singh, then Panchkula commissioner; and Pankaj Agarwal, then chairman, Haryana State Agricultural Marketing Board (HSAAMB), who were arrested earlier in connection with the case. It has also named Mohammad Shafiq, then managing director of Haryana Power Corporation Ltd (HPCL), Saket Kumar, then commissioner and secretary, development and panchayats department of the Haryana government, who were arrested in connection with the case. It has also named Mohammad Shafiq, then managing director of Haryana Power Corporation Ltd (HPCL), Saket Kumar, then commissioner and secretary, development and panchayats department of the Haryana government, who were arrested in connection with the case.

CBI filed the charge sheet without obtaining prosecution sanction for the IAS officers, which effectively means the trial court cannot take cognisance of it or the police investigation report.



Disha Saian

The charge sheet also names three IDFC First Bank officials—Shamim Ahmad Dar, Sudha Goyal and Kuldeep Singh—one AU Small Finance Bank official Charanjit Singh Randhawa, and nine Haryana government officials—Deepak Kausik, Rajesh Gaur, Prince Sharma, Saurav Kumar, Parveen Kumar, Surender Jain, Surinder Kaur, Amit Kumar, and Jugal Kishore.

They have been charged with criminal conspiracy, cheating, destruction of evidence, forgery, falsification of accounts, criminal breach of trust and abetment among others, under BNS, besides for bribery and criminal misconduct under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

The alleged financial embezzlement came to light on February 24 with the arrest of Ribhav Rishi and Abhay Kumar, both former employees of IDFC First Bank, along with business partners Swati Singla and Abhishek Singla of Swastik Desh Project.

Earlier, CBI had charged 18 other individuals, including two bank officials and two bank employees, in the case. With the latest charge sheet, the total number of accused charge-sheeted in the case has risen to 37.

KERALAM TO OBEY VANDE MATARAM PROTOCOL WHEN VP ATTENDS EVENT

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Wednesday said the state government would follow the prescribed central protocol when the President, Vice-President or Prime Minister attends an event in the state, while reiterating his party's position on the reclamation of Vande Mataram.

Responding to a question about the controversy over the full recitation of the national song at the recent valedictory function of the week-long Onam celebrations attended by Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan and Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arier in Thiruvananthapuram, Sathesan said the state government could not reject the central protocol applicable to such programmes. "When the President, Vice-President or Prime Minister attends a programme, the protocol is decided by the Centre," he said.

At a press conference after the monsoon session ended on August 13, Congress general secretary for communications Jairam Ramesh had said "Stalling the Bill was one of the Opposition's five achievements."

Apex court orders AG, SG oversight in BCI decisions

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday put the functioning of the Bar Council of India (BCI) under a tighter oversight mechanism, directing that the Attorney General for India and Solicitor General must be "actively associated" with every policy decision taken by the apex lawyers' body until it is reconstituted through fresh elections.

A bench, comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and justices Joydip Bagchi and V. Mohana, also clarified that BCI chairman Manan Kumar Mishra's present continuance in office cannot be treated as an arrangement extending up to 2030, observing that, prima facie, his position is only a "pro tem" continuation until a freshly constituted council elects its office-bearers.

The court's intervention came during a hearing on a batch of petitions concerning elections to state bar councils, in which a fresh challenge was mounted against Mishra's continuance as BCI chairman and the validity of notifications purporting to extend the tenure of the chairman and vice-chairman of the council up to 2030.



The SC said the current BCI chairman's term cannot be treated as an arrangement extending up to 2030.

The top court's directions assume significance coming days after it had criticised the BCI's intervention in the controversy over the NALSAR University of Law's 2026 graduating batch. Mishra had initially directed state bar councils to enrol the students owing to their protest over inviting the CJI for the convocation, before withdrawing the freeze and eventually closing proceedings against the batch.

Mishra subsequently apologised to the students for any hurt caused by his words or the Council's actions.

On Wednesday, the bench said that its immediate concern was not the conduct of any individual but the institutional functioning of the BCI and the

need to restore the statutory electoral scheme after state bar council elections were held pursuant to the court's directions.

The controversy before the court centred on BCI notifications issued in 2025 that purported to give Mishra and vice-chairperson S Prabhakaran a five-year tenure, despite sub-missions that Rule 12(2) of the BCI Rules prescribes a two-year tenure for the chairman and vice-chairman of the council.

Senior advocate Madhavi Divan, appearing for the petitioners, told the bench that Mishra had been unanimously elected chairman on March 2, 2025, for a term beginning April 17, 2025 and ending April 16, 2030. She pointed out that a January 9, 2025 resolution had purported to extend the tenure of the chairman and vice-chairman from three years to five years, even though the Rules prescribed only two years.

At this, the bench questioned how such an extension could operate when the Rules themselves prescribed a two-year tenure. "Interestingly, it purports to extend the tenure from three years to five years, whereas the Rules prescribe only two years," it observed.

Divan also challenged the reliance on the proviso to Sec-

tion 4(3) of the Advocates Act, which permits BCI members to continue until their successors are elected. She argued that a provision intended to prevent an administrative vacuum had effectively been used to avoid elections and perpetuate existing office-holders.

The bench, however, said the proviso was only a transitional and ad hoc mechanism and that the controversy surrounding it may no longer survive now that elections to state bar councils had been completed.

The key development, it said, was that newly elected state bar councils must now exercise their statutory power under Section 4(1)(c) of the Advocates Act to elect their representatives to the BCI. Those representatives would thereafter elect the BCI chairman and vice-chairman. "Is there any doubt that the present office-bearers cannot continue indefinitely until 2030?" the court asked.

The court also addressed concerns raised over the concentration of power within the BCI, including allegations regarding the creation and functioning of trusts controlled by present and former BCI office-bearers.

The matters have been posted for September 23.

M.P. WOMAN GETS 4 LIFE TERMS FOR KILLING CHILDREN

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BHOPAL: A 40-year-old woman has been sentenced to four separate terms of life imprisonment for killing her four children by pushing them into a well after a quarrel with her husband in Garoh area of Mandla district of Madhya Pradesh in July 2024, according to an advocate aware of the matter.

First additional sessions judge of Garoh, Niranjana Kumar Panchal, on Tuesday sentenced Suganbai Banjara to life imprisonment for each of the four deaths and imposed a fine of ₹2,000 on each count, said Dilip Narwal, government advocate. The four life sentences will run consecutively, he added.

The court order said, "The husband harassed her physically in inebriated state and upset with harassment she pushed her four children into a well located on their farm and later she jumped in after them on July 14, 2024. Villagers saw this and rescued Suganbai, but the children lost their lives," the order reads.

ASP Hemlata Kuril said, "On July 13, 2024, the husband allegedly beat the family and threw them out of the house in the rain. Suganbai took her children to an Anganwadi centre for the night. The next morning, she went to the fields with them and jumped into the well as she didn't want to leave her children alone."

2 soldiers missing after training boat capsizes; search underway

[HATHNIKUND BARRAGE]

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KARNAL: A joint search-and-rescue operation by security and response forces is underway at Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana's Yamunanagar district after two soldiers of the 1 Para Special Forces went missing in the Yamuna during a training exercise after their boat developed a technical snag, officials said on Wednesday.

The incident occurred on Tuesday evening during a training exercise involving five personnel, including the two who went missing.

According to a statement by the Chandigarh-based defence public relations officer (PRO), the boat got caught in strong currents towards the downstream barrage.

The teams made swift efforts to retrieve the boat. However, the boat got stuck in strong eddies around the sluice gates and capsized, resulting in the crew getting swept away by the strong currents. Two members of the crew are presently missing, the PRO said.

While three soldiers managed to swim to safety, strong currents swept the remaining two personnel downstream.



A search and rescue operation underway at the Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana's Yamunanagar district on Wednesday.

However, unconfirmed reports suggest that a body was recovered late Wednesday night several km away from the site, hours after a life jacket and some equipment were recovered from the river.

The army and the district administration is tight-lipped on both the recoveries.

The army also refused to confirm the identifications and ranks of the missing soldiers, citing "sensitivity of the case."

Search and rescue teams from the army, Indian Air Force, National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) units from Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, local police, and the civil

administration have deployed all available resources for the operation. Two helicopters are conducting aerial surveys along the barrage and downstream parallel canals—the Western Yamuna Canal (WYC) toward Haryana and the Eastern Yamuna Canal (EYC) toward Uttar Pradesh.

To facilitate the search, the Haryana irrigation and water resources department reduced water discharge at the barrage and WJC following a request from the army.

Pratap Nagar police station SHO Inspector Rohtash confirmed that the multi-agency operation is underway, though the missing personnel have yet to be traced.

Agencies directed to monitor cash deposits in border areas

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NEW DELHI: Large-scale unusual cash deposits in bank branches located near India's border areas came under scrutiny at the National Security Strategies (NSS) Conference of the Intelligence Bureau (IB) last week, with Union home minister Amit Shah learnt to have directed security agencies to closely examine these transactions and keep a watch on such activity, highly placed officials told HT.

The two-day conference was held in Delhi on August 24 and 25 and was attended by 850 offi-

cers from across the country, including the directors general of police of all border states.

"A key issue that came up during the conference was large-scale, unusual cash deposits over a period of time in certain bank branches near border districts, much more than seen previously. There is a concern, and efforts are on to ascertain whether these deposits and foreign remittances from bank branches near the borders, have any anti-India dimension," said an officer familiar with the discussions, requesting anonymity.

Among the areas where intelligence agencies have been asked

to maintain a close watch are India's western border, West Bengal, Uttarakhand as well as the border states in the North-east of the country. The officials declined to go into the specifics due to security reasons.

The development comes against the backdrop of a nationwide verification exercise launched by the IT Department on August 18 to examine several foreign remittances. The exercise focused on shell entities, the people behind them and professionals who issued Form 15CB certificates for the remittances. Chartered accountants issue such certificates.

SC allows boy's return to dad in Canada after 6 yrs

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has allowed a boy to be returned to his father in Canada after six years, dismissing the mother's appeal against a Delhi High Court order directing the child's repatriation.

"We find no ground to interfere with the impugned order passed by the HC. The special leave petition is accordingly dismissed," a bench of justices MM Sundresh and Prasanna B Varale said in the August 31 order.

The verdict came while hearing the mother's challenge to the HC's July 30 order, which directed her to return the child to Canada within six weeks and hand over tempo-

rary custody to the father. The HC held that permitting litigants to contest child custody proceedings before a foreign court and seek refuge in another jurisdiction after an adverse ruling would undermine the authority of judicial institutions across jurisdictions.

Married in 2015, the couple moved to Canada in 2018 after obtaining permanent residency. Marital disputes led the wife to return to India with their three-year-old son in 2018, without the father's knowledge. In 2020, a Canadian court granted the father temporary sole custody and ordered the child's return to Canada.

7-year-old dies after getting anti-malaria tablet in AP, 53 fall ill

HYDERABAD: A seven-year-old girl had died and 53 others fell ill after being administered chloroquine tablets during a malaria prevention programme in Andhra Pradesh's Polavaram district, officials aware of the matter said.

Preliminary medical assessment suggested the girl might have had an underlying hereditary or familial cardiac condition, said Polavaram district collector K. Dinesh Kumar, adding the batch of tablets has been sent to the Visakhapatnam forensic laboratory for testing.

Assam man held for killing wife, 3 kids over financial strain

SILCHAR: A 48-year-old man from Assam's Dhemaji district was arrested on Wednesday for killing his wife and three children with an axe allegedly after prolonged financial stress. The accused claimed that he was unable to run the family on the ₹10,000 he earned every month, police said.

Jitendra Borah, Simenachapori Police Station in-charge, said, after killing them, Firoz Ali told his neighbours that he was unable to provide his family with a proper life and killed them as he could not cope with the financial strain.

Bengaluru woman arrested for killing 4-month-old twins

BENGALURU: A 43-year-old woman in Bengaluru has been arrested for killing her four-month-old twin daughters, police said.

Starting that she drowned the infants before attempting to hang herself. According to the complaint filed by her husband, the woman became less interested in caring for the infants after their birth. Doctors reportedly told them that her behaviour could be associated with postpartum depression and hormonal imbalance after childbirth, police added.

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[DIVERSION OF TOLL REVENUE]

ED conducts searches in toll plaza fraud case

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LUCKNOW: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted searches at 14 premises across Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Jammu and Kashmir, Madhya Pradesh, the National Capital Region and West Bengal as part of a money-laundering investigation into alleged fraudulent toll collection at National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) toll plazas.

A Lucknow zonal ED official said the searches, conducted under Section 17 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, are aimed at unearthing the financial and digital trail of the alleged fraud, identifying beneficiaries and tracing suspected proceeds of crime, officials added.

He said the agency's investigation has allegedly uncovered an organised mechanism designed to bypass the prescribed electronic toll-collec-

tion and accounting system at identified toll plazas.

The investigation stems from a case registered in January 22, 2025. The ED's Ahmedabad Sub-Zonal Office filed an Enforcement Case Information Report in the matter on May 19, 2025.

According to ED, unauthorised software applications named "Mobdata" and "Any" were used to generate toll receipts outside the authorised system. Such receipts allegedly enabled toll collections to be diverted without being reflected in the official accounting mechanism.

The agency said forensic examination of digital systems, along with records obtained from NHAI, corroborated the deployment of such software. The findings prompted the ED to widen its probe beyond the functioning of individual toll plazas to trace the broader network allegedly involved in the diversion of toll revenues.

Digital forensic examination

of devices seized during the probe has identified numerous toll-wise portals, credentials, transaction records and communications allegedly linked to the operation of the unauthorised system.

Investigators are examining digital trails to establish the alleged operators, how the collections were routed and the beneficiaries.

The agency said forensic examination of digital systems, coupled with records obtained from NHAI, has corroborated the alleged deployment of unauthorised software at toll plazas.

The findings have prompted the agency to widen its investigation beyond individual toll points and examine the broader network allegedly involved in the collection and diversion of toll revenue.

The agency has not disclosed the names of people, entities and the premises being searched, or the quantum of toll revenue allegedly diverted.

JAWAN POSTED AT NDA FOUND DEAD ON RAILWAY TRACKS IN PUNE

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PUNE: A jawan posted at the National Defence Academy (NDA) in Khadkavasa was found dead on railway tracks in Pune on Tuesday evening, according to a defence release issued on Wednesday.

Havaldar Jagtar Singh, a native of Manasa district in Punjab, was posted at the tri-service training academy. The Railway Protection Force (RPF) found his body on the railway track between Khadki and Shivajinagar at around 5.30pm on September 1.

The body was subsequently sent to the Government Hospital in Aundh for post-mortem examination. His next of kin have been informed about the incident, the defence release said.

A Court of Inquiry (COI) has been ordered to ascertain the circumstances surrounding his death.

The Southern Command PRO described the incident as "unfortunate" and said the inquiry would establish the circumstances leading to the jawan's death.

Further details from Central Railway and the RPF are awaited.

Fighter pilot who was shot down over Pak quits IAF, joins pvt airline

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NEW DELHI: Group Captain Abhinandan Varthaman, who was awarded Vir Chakra for shooting down a Pakistani F-16 during a dogfight over the Line of Control (LoC) on February 27, 2019, has quit the Indian Air Force and joined a private airline, officials aware of the matter said on Wednesday.

He left the IAF on March 31 and later joined Fly91, a regional carrier, the officials said asking not to be named.

The dogfight in which Abhinandan was involved took place a day after the IAF's Mirage-2000s struck targets in Pakistan's Balakot in response to the Pulwama suicide attack in Kashmir in which 40 Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) personnel were killed on February 14, 2019. He was a wing commander then.

Abhinandan, then 35, scripted military aviation history by joining an F-16, seconds before his own MIG-21 Bison was hit by a missile forcing him to eject. Experts then hailed it as the first ever kill of an F-16 by a MIG-21 Bison, fighter jets of two different generations.

He was captured after he bailed out of his aircraft, but Pakistan returned him to India on March 1, 2019, after holding him captive for almost 60 hours.

Vir Chakra is India's third-highest wartime gallantry award, after Param Vir Chakra and Maha Vir Chakra. Abhinandan's citation,



Abhinandan Varthaman

published in the Gazette of India in December 2019, said he courageously engaged the Pakistani aircraft package despite his "immense numerical and technological superiority," and his aggressive manoeuvres forced the enemy aircraft into tactical chaos. In February 2019, Abhinandan was posted with a MIG-21 Bison squadron and was on 'operational readiness platform' duty at air force station Srinagar when a large Pakistani Air Force fighter aircraft package was detected heading towards LoC. Abhinandan was scrambled to intercept this package five minutes after it was detected.

The citation said he pursued a retreating enemy fighter aircraft and in the ensuing aerial combat, shot down an F-16.

"However, in the melee, one of the enemy aircraft fired multiple advanced BVR missiles, one of which hit his aircraft forcing him to eject in enemy territory," it said.



Vice Adm Dilip Raghavan

VICE ADMIRAL RAGHAVAN TAKES OVER SERVICES TOP MEDICAL ROLE

NEW DELHI: Surgeon Vice Admiral Dilip Raghavan has assumed the appointment of Director General Hospital Services (Armed Forces), officials said on Wednesday.

He joined the Armed Forces Medical College (AFMC), Pune in 1985 and completed his MBBS in 1989. He was commissioned into the Indian Navy in December 1989. During his career, he has held several important medical and instructional appointments. He completed his MS (ENT) from AFMC, Pune in 1998 and subsequently underwent a two-year Fellowship in ENT Microsurgery and Cochlear Implant Surgery at the Madras ENT Research Foundation, Chennai.

HTC

Nephew of Baghel's PA arrested in CGSPC case

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RAIPUR: Utkarsh Chandrakar, the nephew of former Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel's PA K.K. Chandrakar, has been arrested in connection with alleged irregularities, question-paper leaks and corruption in examinations conducted by the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission (CGSPC), the Enforcement Directorate (ED) said on Wednesday.

In a statement, the agency said Utkarsh was arrested on Tuesday under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, after its investigation allegedly established his involvement in activities connected with the proceeds of crime. It added that searches were conducted at five locations in Chhattisgarh as part of its money laundering investigation

into the CGSPC exam irregularities.

According to the agency, its investigation found that CGSPC examination question papers were allegedly leaked in 2020 and 2021 to relatives of accused persons and selected candidates through private brokers in exchange for illegal gratification.

The ED said its investigation revealed proceeds of crime of more than ₹3 crore collected in cash by Utkarsh and Dr Vikash Chandrakar from job aspirants after allegedly assuring them that leaked CGSPC-2021 examination papers would be supplied to them.

The ED alleged that Utkarsh used the name, position and influence of K.K. Chandrakar to collect money from aspirants and influence of K.K. Chandrakar to collect money from them. Further investigation is underway, the agency said.

Bill proposing system to assess drivers in works

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NEW DELHI: A bill proposing to introduce a points-based system for drivers that could even lead to cancellation of licence for consistent bad driving is being readied to be presented before Parliament, Union road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday.

Under the proposed system, points will be deducted in a graded manner based on the seriousness of traffic violations, with licences liable to suspension or cancellation after a specified limit.

"After a particular limit, the licence will get suspended or even cancelled because those who are hugely making mistakes will need money from them. Further investigation is underway, the agency said.

The system is being proposed against the backdrop of what Gadkari described as the continuing challenge of human behaviour on roads, despite improvements in road engineering and digitalisation. The Chennai Mathematical Institute was involved with formulating the grading system, officials had earlier said.

Gadkari also proposed studying the efficacy of a reward-based road-safety model being implemented in Nagpur for wider adoption. The pilot uses artificial intelligence-enabled cameras and scanners to track driving behaviour and rewards motorists who follow traffic rules. The rewards include free petrol, discounts on insurance premiums and offers from participating brands.

Gadkari said the model should be studied to encourage people who "never violate the law".

KHARGE DEMANDS SOCIAL SECURITY FOR FARMERS

NEW DELHI: Emphasising that the Congress is forever committed to rural India, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge demanded social security for farmers, rural and tribal families to ensure that these communities become partners in India's development.

Conferring the YS Rajasekhara Reddy Awards to MS Swaminathan Research Foundation, Kharge said, "Our rural communities do not need to be remembered only when there is a drought, a flood, a crop failure or an election. They deserve a development model that gives them security before the crisis arrives."

"We need to ask whether our farmers have a fair market, whether rural families have decent livelihoods, whether our women have economic independence, and whether our villages have the infrastructure and services that allow young people to build a future there," he said.

AIMIM spokesperson Asim Waqar joins Cong

NEW DELHI: AIMIM spokesperson Syed Asim Waqar joined the Congress on Wednesday and took a swipe at the Asaduddin Owaisi-led party, alleging that it pays lip service to removing the BJP from power but on the ground fights those seeking to dislodge the ruling party. "I felt that if we keep fighting the opposition, then we are helping the BJP. I have decided that if we are true nationalists and want to remove the BJP then our objective should be to fight the BJP. If we are fighting the enemies of the BJP then we are BJP's friends," he said.

Tiger mauls woman sanitation worker in Raj biological park

JAIPOUR: A 42-year-old woman labourer was mauled to death by a tiger after it was allegedly released into an enclosure where she and four other women were cutting grass at Nahargarh Biological Park in Jaipur on Wednesday morning.

The deceased was identified as Sugna Devi, a resident of Nangal Susawatan village in Jamwaramgarh. The incident took place around 10am when the tiger, named Shivaji, was being released for public display.

Jarange-Patil agrees to take water but continues fast

JALNA: Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil on Wednesday evening agreed to take water and undergo saline treatment after BJP MLA Prasad Lad met him on the government's behalf, but maintained that his indefinite fast would continue until all his demands were met. Jarange-Patil began his latest indefinite hunger strike at Antarwali Sarani on August 29, demanding reservation for Marathas and immediate issuance of Kumbi certificates.

ODISHA COURT JUNKS PETITION AGAINST PANDIAN

BHUBANESWAR: A court on Wednesday dismissed a criminal revision petition against former Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik and ex-IAF officer VK Pandian in an alleged crore from the state exchequer by undertaking 300 helicopter tours.

Khorda district sessions judge Biranchi Narayan Mohanty said the petitioner failed to substantiate any offence, did not follow the mandatory procedure under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS), and lacked locus standi to file the complaint. The court also found no illegality in the March 25 order of the Sub-Divisional Judicial Magistrate (SDJM), Bhubaneswar, which dismissed the original complaint. The revision petition was rejected as "devoid of merit," the court order said.

Sudhir Charan Mohanty had lodged a complaint against Patnaik and Pandian at the Capital Police Station in 2024, alleging they used helicopter tours using state funds without official sanctions.

DEBABRATA MOHANTY

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RAM TEMPLE TRUST CEO

endra Mishra, the newly named CEO of the trust, was one of the top planners of Operation Sindoor and received a medal for distinguished service of exceptional order for his role during the four-day military confrontation with Pakistan last year. Mishra, a fighter combat leader and an experimental test pilot, was on April 30 as the Air Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Subroto Park-based Western Air Command.

"I am full of gratitude, and I consider myself a very fortunate person," he told HT. Bhagchandka, former additional advocate general Madan Mohan Pandey, a resident of Ayodhya who fought the Ram Jannabhoomi title case in the 1990s, and Nirmala Yadav, former principal of PG College, Shikhabad, were the new trust members. Yadav is the first woman member of the body that oversees and manages the Ram Temple.

VHP international president Alok Kumar welcomed the appointment of Bhagchandka, describing him as a "frontline soldier" of the Ram Jannabhoomi movement.

"Out of three names shortlisted by the search committee, the trust selected former Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra for the CEO's post," said former interim general secretary Krishna Mohan after the meeting. However, no decision could be taken on the position of spokesperson for the trust, added Mohan. A native of Bhopalpur village under Bhatpar Rani police station in Deoria district of eastern Uttar Pradesh, Mishra's appointment as CEO for three years marks a shift from trustee-led management to professional corporate oversight for civil security, logistics, crowd and multi-crore funds.

The appointments mark the most significant effort to shake-up the trust's functioning that had come under mounting criticism after the controversy over donation collections at the Ram Temple.

The BJP welcomed the appointment of retired Air Marshal Mishra as the CEO, stressing the Trust operates independently. BJP's Rajya Sabha MP and former deputy Uttar Pradesh deputy chief minister Dinesh Sharma said, "Shri Ram Jannabhoomi Trust is an independent body and its decisions uphold religious sentiments without external interference."

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav asked why employees arrested in the alleged temple donation theft case were still in jail while senior officials had been given a clean chit. Rajya Sabha MP Ramvilas Patil (SP) also questioned the government's action against those

allegedly involved in the earlier irregularities. "New committees are being formed and a new CEO is being appointed, but what has the government done against those who committed the earlier wrongdoing?" he said.

The donation theft controversy first surfaced on June 7 when Samajwadi Party leader Tej Narayan "Pawan" Pandey alleged that donations worth ₹5 crore to ₹7.5 crore were siphoned off from temple offerings. On June 13, the state government set up the first SIT comprising Lucknow divisional commissioner Vijay Vishwas Pant, inspector general of police (Lucknow range) Kiran S and special secretary (Finance) Neel Ratan).

On June 25, a first information report was registered against eight named accused and other unidentified people under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sections 306, 316(5), 317(4), 317(5), 61 and 3(5), relating to offences such as criminal breach of trust, cheating, theft and criminal conspiracy, along with Section 131(a) of the Prevention of Corruption Act.

All eight accused named in the FIR — Anukul Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu, Manish Yadav, Subhash Srivastava, Avinash Shukla, Ram Shankar Mishra and Karunesh Pandey — were arrested on June 26 and nearly ₹8 lakh was recovered from their homes. A second SIT was constituted in July following the Supreme Court's direction for an IPS-led investigation. On August 17, the first SIT's final report flagged "gross lapses" in the functioning of the trust and questioned the State Bank of India's (SBI) role and the lack of professional financial management in the Trust. However, it found no evidence of financial impropriety at the leadership level.

Amid mounting criticism, on July 6, the Trust accepted the resignations of Rai as general secretary and Mishra as member, removed administrator Gopal Rao, and announced a three-member panel to appoint a new chief executive officer as it sought to restore its image. The trust announced the formation of a three-member committee to identify a CEO, comprising retired judge Pramod Kohli, retired army lieutenant general Vishnu Kant Chaturvedi and National Institute of Technology Rourkela chairman Suraj Haware.

The committee submitted a panel of three candidates after AI-enabled screening of 5,585 applicants and 16 face-to-face interviews. The two other short-listed candidates were former Major General Sanjay Pratap Singh and WHO Shrutu Bhargava. Krishna Mohan said, "The Wednesday meeting was attended by the trust's chief Mahant Nriya Gopal Das, Giri and other trustees, while several members participated online. Giri said Krishna Mohan had played a crucial role in steering the trust through 'troubled times'."

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

He said the trust may appoint a joint CEO or deputy CEO if required and would prepare an SOP specifying the CEO's duties and responsibilities. "We have to make Ayodhya the world's cultural capital. We will not leave any stone unturned for this," he added.

IRAN-INDO FLIGHT Today, inventories are even more depleted. "The strikes follow weeks of relative calm, during which the US had said it was pivoting from military action to economic pressure on Tehran. Crude prices spiked after the marginal gain last month and remain about 30% higher since the war began in late February. Diesel products such as refined have rallied even harder due to the Middle East conflict and ongoing war between Russia and Ukraine."

That pain was reflected in the US on Wednesday. Weekly data from the Energy Information Administration showed that crude refinery runs soared to the highest in seven years, while gasoline imports fell to 370,000 barrels a day last week, below levels for the same time in 2020. In the Midwest, refineries are operating at an unprecedented 103.5% of capacity to capitalize on surging margins.

The escalating risks to shipping imperil supplies of oil, refined products, gas and other commodities, adding to inflationary pressures on central bankers. Meanwhile, the buffer provided by strategic petroleum reserves has thinned because governments have already drawn on stockpiles during months of disruption.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said 17 million barrels of crude exited Hormuz on Monday, stating that the Islamic Republic doesn't have control of the strait at a press conference after a Group of 20 meeting in Asheville, North Carolina. Later, US Energy Secretary Chris Wright reiterated that figure and added that exports are averaging about 8 million barrels a day. An additional 4 million to 5 million barrels a day are bypassing the waterway via pipelines, he told reporters while en route to Venezuela. Prior to the Iran war, about a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural

gas was shipped through Hormuz to global markets.

Late Tuesday, Trump said on social media that he "couldn't care less" if Iran signed a deal, adding that the country's economy was "totally collapsing." Prior to the post, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said renewed fighting had "only tightened the lock" on Hormuz, IRIB reported.

The conflict seems stuck in a phase where the tussles for control of Hormuz bring recurring hostilities, which nourishes the risk premium embedded in oil prices," said Norbert Ruecker, head of economics at Julius Baer Group Ltd.

GOA-INDO FLIGHT

related to one of the engines. Tuesday's was the second IndoGo flight to face an engine snag in the past month.

On August 11, a Kolkata-Chennai flight made a priority landing after declaring an emergency when its left engine developed problems on approach.

The captain, Singh underlined, stayed calm and tried to cut the tension in the cabin. "He did not put us into any anxiety while he was doing his work to the best of his ability... Moments before touchdown, the pilot informed passengers that one of the engines had failed and that his aim was to bring the aircraft safely to the ground," he said.

The aircraft landed safely at 9.45am with 229 people on board.

Singh said the landing was smooth despite the turbulence and crosswinds.

"When we landed, everybody heaved a sigh of relief and prayed," Singh recounted.

The aircraft, registered VT-JLZ, is a 4.8-year-old A321neo powered by two CFM International LEAP-1A engines.

The LEAP-1A is one of two engine options on the A320neo family — the backbone of IndiGo's fleet that also includes the A321neo — the other being Pratt & Whitney's PW1000G geared turbofan. The CFM engine has broadly had a smoother in-service record than the Pratt & Whitney unit, which has been dogged by durability problems and a powder-metal contamination defect that at its peak grounded dozens of IndiGo aircraft.

Passengers disembarked in usual fashion and weren't made to follow any emergency protocol, said Singh, who was seated in row 3.

For a few seconds, Singh nearly questioned fate. "I had some thoughts — why did I change my plan? Why did I change this flight?"

"But then, god's grace and the pilot's skill saved us."

NEPAL FLOODS

floodwaters and debris. Some tunnels contain chambers with air supplies, and rescuers were trying to reach about 900 missing workers.

There is a high chance that dozens of workers may be found alive after a week trapped in an underground chamber at Nepal's Rasuwagadhi hydropower project, a Nepal Electricity Authority official said.

"In Rasuwagadhi, we think 46 people are trapped in a room-like structure in the tunnel," Amshu Kiran Shahi, a member of the Nepal Electricity Authority, told Reuters.

Prime Minister Balendra Shah told parliament the search would continue.

"Our priority remains clear: To continue our search and rescue operations, find those who are still missing and continue supporting everyone affected," he said.

Major rescue operations were under way or planned at four hydropower projects.

Two sites, where about 90 people are missing, offered the strongest prospect of finding survivors because of the presence of air inside the tunnels, Shahi said.

At Trishuli-3A, officials believe there was a dry chamber inside and expected oxygen to be flowing through the tunnel, with pipes also being used to push oxygen inside, Shahi said.

Specialised rescue teams from India, China and the United States were involved in the tunnel rescue attempts.

Across the border in Tibet, China raised its death toll to 21, with 541 others still listed as missing.

The update came after Beijing fully reopened the road leading to the Gyirong border crossing, which was obliterated by the giant wall of water and debris that crashed through the area, allowing heavy machinery to reach the core disaster zone for the first time.

Chinese state broadcaster CCTV showed excavators, rescue teams, search dogs and life-detection equipment being deployed in a narrow mountain gorge where rain, unstable cliffs and a fast-flowing river have hampered operations.

Rescuers are focusing on structures including the inspection building, parking lots, and dormitories in the now flattened area as they conduct a "deep search" for survivors, local newspaper Tibet Daily reported on Wednesday, citing a media briefing by the government.

China's official toll of those missing includes 104 Nepali citizens, 49 Indians as well as 33 Latvians who are believed to be part of two tourist groups. Most Indians were part of groups visiting Lake Mansarovar and Mount Kailash in Tibet, holy pilgrimage sites for Hindus.

T'gana min refuses to quit, dares Cong high command to sack her

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: Telangana forests and endowments minister Konda Surekha on Wednesday refused to step down from her post and challenged the Congress high command to sack her, if it decides to do so, for allegedly violating the party discipline.

Surekha, who flew to New Delhi on Tuesday, met Congress national president Mallikarjun Kharge on Wednesday and presented her version of the controversy triggered by her daughter Konda Sushmita's outburst against the party and Telangana chief minister A Revanthi Reddy at a meeting in Warangal on August 19.

Earlier in the day, the chief minister met party top leaders to discuss the situation in the state Congress. A party leader familiar with the developments said Revanthi Reddy insisted on firm action against Surekha and former minister G Chinnna Reddy, who also made remarks



Konda Surekha

against him and the party.

Surekha, who had already submitted her explanation to the show-cause notice issued by the Telangana PG disciplinary committee on August 20, told reporters in New Delhi that she had also given written explanations to senior party leaders Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and party general secretary KC Venugopal.

She clarified she was prepared to face any decision taken by the party leadership. "There is no question of resigning from the cabinet. So far, the high command has not asked me to resign. If the high command

wants to dismiss me because of the pressure being exerted by Revanthi Reddy, let it do so," she told the media.

The minister said she had requested the party leadership not to hold her responsible for statements made independently by her daughter.

"My daughter is an independent person. She got married and is now the daughter-in-law of another family. She has the right to speak about her own life. Her life is her choice, just as my political life and that of my husband are our choices," Surekha said. She maintained that she had been performing well as a minister. She said she wanted to continue in office and had conveyed the same request to the party high command.

Surekha also objected to the party seeking an explanation from her over her daughter's comments. "I will neither respond to nor endorse my daughter's remarks. Many people sleep every day, and Sushmita is one among them," she said.

Vijay: TN will drop cases against farmers, teachers

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government will withdraw cases registered against farmers and teachers for peacefully protesting for their rights and demands during the previous DMK regime, chief minister C Joseph Vijay said in the Assembly on Wednesday.

Making a statement under Rule 10, Vijay said the decision was taken on humanitarian grounds and based on democratic principles.

During the previous regime, several cases were registered between May 2021 and April 2026 against farmers and teachers who protested over their livelihoods, rights and social welfare demands, he said.

Tracing the background, he said in Tiruvannamalai district, farmers were protesting the expansion of a SIPCOT industrial park, with some even booked under the Goondas Act. Farmers also

held continuous protests against the proposed Paradur airport, fearing its impact on agricultural land, water bodies and livelihoods. "The Paradur airport project has been recently dropped by the TJK government. Cases registered inhumanely by the previous government remain pending against these farmers, who protested demanding the scrapping of the airport project out of concern that their agricultural lands, water bodies, and livelihoods would be affected," Vijay said.

"Farmers are the backbone of our society, while teachers form the absolute foundation of societal progress by lighting the lamp of education," Vijay said. Raising objections, senior DMK leader KN Nehru said the government could not unilaterally withdraw the cases and that courts had to decide the matter.

Assembly Speaker JCD Prabakaran rejected the objections, saying Vijay's announcement under Rule 10 was "entirely as per the rules".

EX-MAOIST NOW COORDINATOR FOR TRIBAL SCHEME

Pradip Kumar Mitra

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NAGPUR: Gondwana University in Maharashtra on Monday appointed former politburo member and key strategist of the proscribed CPI (Maoist), Mallajula Venugopal Rao, alias Bhupathi, as a coordinator for its 'Ekal' programme scheme, which is aimed at empowering tribal communities.

Bhupathi, 71, operated across the Dandakaranya region spanning Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana, and Odisha. He surrendered last year alongside 60 armed Maoist before the Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis.

"The university recently advertised the position, for which Bhupathi applied. Following a standard selection process and consultations with the police and district administration, he was offered the role," said vice chancellor Dr Bokare.

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{ OUR TAKE }

The uncertain new world

The renewed fighting in West Asia brings to light the reality of today's uncertain world, where conflict and imprudent escalation is the norm

A disturbing sense of déjà vu has blanketed West Asia. American warplanes have, again, struck Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps positions across southern Iran—Qeshm Island, Bandar Abbas, Chabahar, Jask—after a brief lull in a war that has simmered since the assassination of Iran's supreme leader back in February. Iran has retaliated by attacking US bases in the region.

It is tragicomic that after a negotiated détente, the two countries have stumbled into a second round of a war that has already gutted global stock markets, disturbed supply chains, set oil prices on fire, and disrupted almost every facet of the global economy. What is happening in West Asia is a troubling portent of conflicts in the global order—where wars continue not because of singular disputes but due to the hubris of the leaders squaring off, playing to their domestic galleries where headline states help position them as strong figures. The so-called international community has been shown its (very limited) place in negotiating any cessation to the hostilities which now run the risk of turning into another prolonged war of attrition, akin to the one raging in Ukraine for four years now. Reports of Iran developing a ramjet propulsion system to add substantially faster anti-ship and land-attack cruise missiles with the help of Russia's missile specialists hint at a prolonged West Asian disturbance. Iran has gauged the unpredictability of Donald Trump's policies and likely decided to stretch the conflict until the White House gets a new occupant, or at least the incumbent suffers some electoral setback in the 2026 midterms.

Clearly, this is a new, uncertain world where conflict and imprudent escalation will be the norm; the 21st-century economy and its interconnected nodes of production, consumption and supply chains will ensure that no nation can remain either unaffected or isolationist. What should India do? The country's economy has shown remarkable resilience in the previous quarter by clocking 7.8% GDP growth. But the fresh volley of missile attacks—coupled with a global selloff, renewed worries around disruptions to oil flows, and the constant shadow of conflict hanging over two million Indians living and working in the Gulf States—shows that New Delhi is not out of the woods yet. It will have to chart a careful diplomatic course, run a tighter fiscal ship while working to plug capacity gaps. The prime minister's recent warning about reigning in profligate spending might soon seem prescient.

Cruelty has no place in the classroom

What do a three-year-old boy in outer Delhi's Majpur, a six-year-old boy in Andhra Pradesh's Visakhapatnam, a 10-year-old girl in east Delhi's Vinod Nagar and a 16-year-old girl in Haryana's Faridabad have in common? Avoidable tragedy.

The parents of all four children have alleged that they suffered cruelty at the hands of teachers and school staff, in some cases involving allegations of inhuman punishment or irate teachers lashing out. In Majpur, the boy was allegedly tied to a chair for hours and subjected to severe physical abuse over several days at a play school. In Visakhapatnam, police said the boy collapsed in the classroom and died after being slapped by his teacher for not completing his homework. In Vinod Nagar, a 10-year-old girl collapsed and died in hospital after allegedly being made to stand at the back of her class as punishment for forgetting to bring a book. In Faridabad, the student jumped from the third-floor terrace of her school building after allegedly being made to stand in the sun for several hours as punishment.

The allegations are serious and deserve an open and transparent investigation that doesn't try to brush the facts under the carpet. But beyond the particulars of these cases, the four cases point towards a disturbing trend of schools and teachers failing to move on with the times and continuing with outdated forms of instruction and punishment. India has both the learning outcome and school dropout problem—an annual ACER reports show that across India, students cannot read or solve mathematical problems at several levels below their own, and UDISE surveys underline serious problems of dropout at the secondary school level. These are the gaps in education that schools and educators should be focussing on, not on devising cruel and unusual forms of punishment.

Let's not be too casual about the Naxal label

India should not have to choose between national security and democratic freedom. Properly understood, the two reinforce each other

In his Independence Day address from the Red Fort, Prime Minister PM Narendra Modi said armed Naxalists had been decisively weakened but warned of what he called 'dimagi Naxal'—people with a Maoist mindset who, he said, remained alert to opportunities of creating violence and disorder and, therefore, needed to be identified and isolated.

The concern underlying his remarks deserves serious attention. Even when an armed movement loses territory and cadres, the networks and ideas that sustained violence in the first place do not necessarily disappear with the gun. India has paid a heavy price in the Maoist conflict to become complacent. The State has both the right and the duty to ensure that such insurgency does not re-emerge.

That duty carries an equally important democratic obligation: The State must be precise about whom it is targeting, for what conduct, and on what evidence.

Insurgencies are rarely sustained by armed cadres alone. Violent organisations may rely on recruitment, finance, shelter, communications,

propaganda, logistics, and people who facilitate them. Those who finance violence, recruit for it, harbour cadres, assist operations, or conspire to commit offences cannot claim immunity where evidence establishes criminal conduct. The law must take its course—firmly.

The difficulty begins when conduct gives way to presumed thought.

'Dimagi Naxal' is a political expression, not a legal category. Criminal liability cannot rest merely on a presumed state of mind. The law can examine conduct, intent, financing, and incite-ment, and all of these attract legal culpability. What a constitutional democracy must guard against, however, is the slide from evidence to association, and from association to assumption. That distinction goes to the heart of citizenship. A student protesting an examination, a college graduate demanding jobs, a farmer questioning policy, a tribal activist opposing displacement, or a journalist scrutinising a security operation does not become an extremist merely because of these communities, and to the fact that the government may disagree, and the police may regulate protests. But dissent alone cannot make loyalty to India suspect.

India now recognises the distinction. Section 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita deals sternly with acts that endanger India's sovereignty, unity, and integrity, including armed

rebellion and subversive activity. Yet, its explanation protects criticism of government measures or administrative action when aimed at securing change through lawful means and without exciting the activities prohibited by the section.

That is not a concession democracy makes to its critics. It is constitutional democracy in operation.

The PM did not describe recent youth protests as 'dimagi Naxalism', and it would be unfair to attribute such a connection to him. But political expressions rarely remain confined to their original context. Once repeated by parties, television studios and social media, they can expand quickly. That is why clarity matters.

Words spoken from the Red Fort carry exceptional authority. When the PM says that a category of people must be 'identified' and 'isolated', citizens are entitled to know what separates that category from legitimate dissent. If the expression refers to those knowingly enabling Maoist violence, the distinction should be stated clearly, and the law applied to extend merely to radical, unopposed or sharply critical opinion, a democratic India should draw the line.

A republic requires obedience to the Constitution and the law; it does not require unquestioning loyalty to the government of the day and citizens retain the right to disagree. At the same time, civil liberties



Amarinder Singh



A democracy that treats disagreement itself as a security threat risks diminishing the freedom that security is meant to defend.

cannot become camouflage for organised violence. The dividing line is not left versus right, government versus Opposition, or nationalist versus critic. It is between lawful dissent and conduct that knowingly enables violence.

That standard protects the state as much as the citizen. Vague categories can weaken security by blurring the distinction between the genuinely dangerous and those that merely dissent. Intelligence agencies and police should concentrate on networks capable of financing, facilitating or organising violence rather than being drawn into broad ideological scrutiny of inconvenient voices.

India's success against armed Naxalism should, therefore, be followed not by an indiscriminate search for another internal enemy, but by ensuring that areas from which the gun retreats are filled by schools, hospitals, roads, livelihoods, responsive administration and politi-

cal hope. The greatest victory over extremism is not merely that an insurgent no longer carries a rifle. It is that a young person no longer believes a rifle is necessary to be heard.

India should not have to choose between national security and democratic freedom. Properly understood, the two reinforce each other. A State unable to defeat violence cannot protect liberty. But a democracy that treats disagreement itself as a security threat risks diminishing the freedom that security is meant to defend.

If the Naxal gun is finally disappearing from India's forests, that is a major national achievement. The task ahead is equally important: Identify and isolate those who profess violence, but do not allow the Naxal label to hang indiscriminately.

Amarinder Singh is former chief minister of Punjab. The views expressed are personal.

India's pastoralists deserve a new tae to tell

All in all, it's been a good year for a sector that has remained largely invisible. After decades of neglect, the issues facing pastoralist communities and grasslands have finally come into sharper global focus—2026 has been declared the International Year for Rangelands and Pastoralism, with the goal of improving land governance, encouraging investment in the ecosystems that make pastoralism productive, and strengthening market linkages. For India's nearly 60 pastoralist castes and ethnic groups, this is a real morale booster.

The just-constituted United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification (UNCCD COP17) in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, followed by commitments, including a \$1.3 billion finance package for land restoration and drought resilience, and a \$1.2 billion Rangelands Flagship Initiative for pastoralist livelihoods. As part of this, India's environment minister recently launched a guide to the country's grasslands and other open natural ecosystems.

This encouraging news took me back to a field trip with my team to understand what is happening on the ground to the country's grasslands, and to the lives and livelihoods of the pastoralists who depend on them.

We were driving through Pune district, the new highway cutting through harvest-ready fields with ripened bajra swaying gently in the breeze.

We soon came upon a herd of goats and sheep, loosely corralled around makeshift tents put up by Dhangar pastoralists. They were on an increasingly uncertain, unmapped journey from Baramat, where their families are anchored, to the Konkani coast—or wherever shelter, fodder and water could be found. Here, they had camped on a friendly farmer's land, in exchange for the rich fertiliser their animals would leave behind before the group moved on. A few women tended to the animals; the men cooked on an open fire. We settled under the open sky with the Kokre family, and soon shared a hot cup of tea boiled with freshly dried sheep milk.

Our hosts told us many stories, some hopeful, some heartrending—echoing tales we'd heard from herders on the Himalayan slopes and in the deserts of Jaisalmer and Kutch. The good news: Meat and milk still fetched decent prices. The sad news: It was ever harder to find greener pastures to live life on the move. There were the old threats of predators and shrinking commons, and the newer threat of solar and windmill plants fracturing grazing corridors. 'Every night, we worry about where we will set up safe camp,' said Sampath Kokre. 'It is hardest for the women.'

Hidden from the gaze of urbanites, there are anywhere between 10 and 12 million pastoralists in India. For the first time, pastoralist livestock was counted separately as part of the five-yearly livestock census, so better data will soon emerge. Food across 24 states and Union Territories, pastoralists often denied access to grazing lands and water bodies, treated with disrespect, and struggle to be recognised as sustainable, highly productive contributors to a climate-resilient economy. There has long been an

assumption that pastoralism would dwindle as settled agriculture grew. Luckily, that hasn't happened—testimony to the resilience of these communities, and to the fact that, as a production system, pastoralism makes both ecological and economic sense. It is sustainable and profitable, which is why pastoralists have been shifting political, market, climatic and regulatory conditions.

Not many people realise that these nomadic communities manage 30% of India's livestock, generating an annual turnover of about \$11 billion. With more than 500 million animals, India has the largest livestock population of any country. Pastoralist herds include cattle, buffaloes, camels, yaks, sheep, goats, ducks, pigs, and donkeys. In India, such as the Thar desert and high-altitude ecosystems such as Ladakh, where settled agriculture cannot succeed, they convert water and soil into meat, milk, wool, and manure. Pastoralism contributes 10-12% to India's dairy and 70% to its meat economy. The next time you feast on biryani or enjoy a milkshake, think of where the milk and mutton might have come from.

Then, there are the other animal products. India is the world's second-largest wool producer, producing 35 million kg a year, 95% of it from pastoralists. Sheep's wool is excellent for acoustic and thermal insulation, and sought after worldwide for its biodegradable, sustainable properties—Mercedes-Benz, for instance, brands sheep's wool with polymers for seat upholstery and sound/thermal insulation. Decan wool has properties similar to styrofoam and could replace environmentally harmful packaging materials. Wool is also high in phosphorus, and a substantial share of India's agriculture depends on organic fertiliser from pastoralist livestock dung.

Yet, the animals need grazing lands. Sixteen million hectares of grassland cover just 5% of India—an area roughly the size of Bangladesh. Once dismissed as wasteland, grasslands are slowly being understood for the many ecosystem services they provide, including corridors for seed dispersal at a significant scale. These open natural ecosystems (ONEs) harbour migratory and endemic bird species such as the critically endangered Great Indian Bustard, and are home to iconic animals such as the black bear, snow leopard and rhino, along with smaller creatures like the jungle cat and numerous reptiles and insects.

It is now widely acknowledged that pastoralism and grazing sustain the ecological functioning of grassland ecosystems—maintaining grass diversity, recycling nutrients and keeping invasive species at bay. Pastoralists are environmental stewards of the lands their livestock grazes on, not just extractors of value.

Will the developments of this year deepen our understanding of—and respect for—the vital role rangelands and pastoralism play in sustaining biodiversity, storing carbon, and bringing food and fabric to our homes? If so, the Dhangars, like their counterparts, will have a different story to tell.

Rohini Nilekani, chairperson, Rohini Nilekani Philanthropies, is the author of *Samaaj, Sarkaar, Bazaar—A Citizen's First Approach*. The views expressed are personal.

{ BALENDRA SHAN | PRIME MINISTER, NEPAL

This is not only the suffering of Rasuva, Nuwakot and Dhading. It is a shared blow to the heart of the entire country... We have no alternative but to fight with determination and courage

On the Nepal government response to the recent floods

India, China must first settle smaller disputes

In diplomacy, every word and phrase matters. This is especially true when two countries are negotiating a disputed border. The appearance of a phrase 'early and substantial harvest on boundary delimitation' in an eight-point joint China-India statement—the first in 11 years—after the 25th round of talks between the special representatives (SR) is fraught with strategic implications.

The phrase 'early harvest' has been around for over a decade, but the usage of 'substantial' is substantial, even though all its implications are not yet clear. This comes on the eve of Chinese President Xi Jinping's first visit to New Delhi since 2019 and amidst moves by the two sides to step up their economic and investment ties. 'Early harvest' made its first appearance in a Chinese note in the wake of the 2017 Doklam crisis which saw the two sides engaged in a border dispute. The Sikkim-Tibet border had been delimited and demarcated by the Anglo-Chinese Convention of 1890. Both sides agree with the border alignment here, though India has differences on the trijunction at Doklam.

On the eve of the Mamallapuram summit in August 2018, the Chinese said that they had agreed to create no-patrol zones at certain sites, and the 22nd round of the SRs' meeting in New Delhi that December, the Chinese said that the two sides 'exchanged views on the early harvest of boundary negotiations'. Reportedly, India turned down the early harvest offer at the time.

But all this went up in smoke with the clash in the Galwan Valley and the first casualties along the LAC since 1957. Relations between the two plunged to their lowest.

In October 2024, through patient diplomacy and an insistence that India will not normalise relations as long as the situation in Ladakh was abnormal, the Chinese side slowly backed off. It agreed to create no-patrol zones at certain sites, and restore Indian patrolling rights in the Depsang bulge and Demchok. However, the additional troops on both sides brought to the region post the Galwan clash have remained, pending discussions on 'de-escalation'.

The two sides then picked up the threads of normalisation. Between 2020-2024 there were no meetings of the SRs and the heads of government. On other words, talks on the resolution of the border issue did not occur.

restarting talks were taken up again. In 2025, at the 24th round of the SRs' meetings, the subject of an 'early harvest' surfaced again. Both the Indian and Chinese press releases spoke of agreement to set up an Expert Group under the WMCC 'to explore early harvest in boundary delimitation in the India-China border areas.'

The recently concluded 25th round gives us a clearer picture.

First, the joint press release signals congruence on the border negotiation.

Second, India is clearly on board with 'early harvest' settlements.

Third, the usage of 'substantial' suggests that this could extend beyond the Sikkim-Tibet border to include the Middle Sector where the disputed boundary is relatively small.

Fourth, the SRs' directive to the Expert Group to work out the terms of reference for their task suggest both are serious about moving ahead.

Fifth, two additional points will be created for senior military commanders meeting in the pattern of Chushul/Moldo. The Indian locations will be Jomoshini in the Middle Sector and Tawang.

Still, the prod of the pudding will be in its eating. The 'early and substantial harvest' planing is a new twist, but a positive one. The reason is because in both the Sikkim-Tibet (220 km) area and the Middle Sector (545 km), the dispute is minimal. The watershed of the Himalayas is fairly clear and both sides largely respect it. The real problems will be in the tri-junctions—the India-Bhutan-China one in Doklam and the India-Nepal-China one in Lipu Lakh.

In 2005, India and China had signed an agreement on the Political Parameters and Guiding Principles of a border settlement based on a comprehensive package settlement of all sectors. Yet, 21 years later, after they found the going tough, they are pragmatically modifying the 2005 agreement, even while publicly affirming it.

A resolution of the larger Sino-Indian boundary will not be easy. A primary reason is the Chinese demand that India cede the Jangmang tract, along with Aksai Chin that it already occupies, is a non-starter for New Delhi. Nevertheless, by settling the relatively smaller disputes first, both sides might build mutual confidence and political momentum necessary to tackle the more intractable issues.

Manoj Joshi is distinguished fellow, Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal.

[U.N. REPORT]

Global temp rise to cross 1.5°C by end of decade

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NEW DELHI: Global temperature rise is likely to cross the 1.5°C threshold by the end of this decade, pushing climate risks and impacts such as intensified extreme weather to increasingly dangerous heights, a UN Environment Programme (UNEP) report on Wednesday said.

The report added that it is still possible to bring temperatures down and achieve global goals as per the 2015 Paris Agreement. Nations agreed to pursue efforts to keep the long-term temperature increase below the 1.5°C threshold under the agreement.

The Limiting Overshoot report was released days after a glacial collapse and flash flood in Nepal left 1,243 people dead and thousands missing, underscoring the fragility of mountains amid a warming climate.

The report identifies an overshoot, peak, and decline pathway as the best remaining option to minimise the magnitude and duration of the overshoot and try to return to below 1.5°C as soon as possible. Even then, it means surpassing the multi-decadal global warming level of 1.5°C, the central long-term temperature goal of the Paris Agreement. Under this optimistic scenario of current government pledges (full implementation of all national climate plans plus meeting additional net-zero targets), the report puts the expected peak temperature rise at 1.8°C.

Under current policies, median projected global warming reaches around 2.6°C by 2100 (range 1.9-3.6°C). Even under one of most optimistic scenarios, which assumes implementation of all Nationally Determined Contributions and long-term net zero targets, central global warming estimates peak at 1.8°C (range 1.7-2.2°C), it says. It adds that human-induced warming is nearing 1.4°C above pre-industrial lev-



Rescuers at Gyirong Port, which was destroyed by a mudslide during the Tibet-Nepal floods, in China on September 2.

els and says global temperatures have been increasing at 0.25°C per decade. "Global warming may reach 1.5°C around the end of this decade."

UNEP said after crossing 1.5°C, risks and impacts will intensify with every extra fraction of a degree and every year. "Anticipated impacts include intensified extreme weather, ecosystem loss, and submergence of Small Island Developing States and low-lying coastal cities. Severe damage to human health, food and water security, nature, infrastructure, and economies is expected," the report says.

It warns that the likelihood of crossing irreversible tipping points increases with the magnitude and duration of higher temperatures. These include the destabilisation of major ice sheets and Amazon rainforest, and disruption of the Atlantic Meridional Overturning Circulation (the currents that move warm surface water north and cold deep water south).

The report says some impacts may emerge abruptly, while others will accumulate over time. It says the duration and severity of the overshoot, peak and decline pathway, and ability of communities to cope will depend on how fast emissions are cut and how quickly adaptation measures are

implemented. "Reductions in methane and other short-lived climate pollutants are particularly important in the immediate term. Enhancing adaptive and mitigation capacity requires strong political will, urgent multilateral action, effective policies and finance — with equity, justice and differentiated responsibilities serving as guiding principles."

UNEP executive director Inger Andersen said there are no good outcomes if the world stays above 1.5°C. "Extreme heatwaves are proving that climate impacts will strike faster, hit harder, and last longer—costing more lives and causing deeper disruption," she said. "Now is the time we must double down on climate action. We can—and must—get on the right path. By cutting emissions, strengthening resilience and adaptation, and ensuring exceedance of 1.5°C is as small as possible."

UN secretary-general António Guterres flagged the risk of rising temperatures, referring to this summer's scorching heat in parts of the world, to raging wildfires and deadly floods. "This is a warning of what lies ahead. We must make the overshoot above 1.5 degrees as small and short as possible. That demands an overshoot of ambition."

NEPAL ASKS U.S., CHINA AND INDIA TO GIVE CLIMATE COMPENSATION

Bloomberg letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Nepal is demanding climate compensation from the world's biggest emitters of greenhouse gases after deadly floods in the country killed more than a thousand people.

China, the US and India have made "extremely large" contributions to climate change and left smaller nations "enduring the price of it," Nepal's foreign minister Sushil Kumar Koirala told Kantipur TV. "Nepal must hold its head high internationally and turn this into a matter of justice," he said. "We will raise this matter explicitly and forcefully on international platforms."

Nepal's demand for climate compensation follows the August 26 floods triggered by a massive rock and ice collapse near the Nepal-Tibet border.

The demand comes ahead of the United Nations annual climate summit in November, where developing nations are expected to press wealthier, high-emitting countries for more funding to cover climate-related losses and damage. "Nepal cannot reduce the world's emissions on behalf of polluters. It cannot protect the Himalayas through adaptation alone while the world continues to burn fossil fuels," the Global Campaign to Demand Climate Justice, a civil society coalition, said on Tuesday.

Khanal said Nepal has sought urgent relief from the UN's Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage. Officials told the fund that recovery costs far exceed domestic resources and that waiting for its board to meet in December would be too late.

[G20]

China derails consensus over imbalance spat: US

Agencies letters@hindustantimes.com

ASHEVILLE/CHAPEL HILL: Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Tuesday that 19 of the members of the G20 had agreed to address streams of "cheap exports" that cause global economic imbalances, but said China had dissented, AP reported.

Bessent made his comments at the end of a two-day meeting with finance ministers and central bankers where he tried to focus on growth, telling reporters he had urged some of his G20 counterparts to take a page from the Trump administration's playbook of using tariffs and other measures to crack down on trade imbalances.

"We believe that non-market-based economies pushing out a never-ending stream of cheap exports is not sustainable," Bessent told reporters, describing the sentiment that all but one G20 member had agreed to.

"It is clear that the country with the world's largest and unsustainable current account



Elon Musk speaks to G20 delegates on Tuesday.

surplus, the People's Republic of China, was the dissenter," Bessent said. The Trump administration, echoing many economists, has blamed China for trade imbalances that have left it with a large trade surplus while the US has a sizable deficit.

Allow AI training on creators' work: US
The US urged G20 countries to

develop rules governing how AI firms use copyrighted material to train their systems, as major US technology firms face mounting lawsuits over the practice, Reuters reported.

US commerce secretary Howard Lutnick told G20 officials that they should embrace "fair use," a principle that allows the unauthorised use of copyright-protected works.

Int'l students in Canada need more reserve funds

Anirudh Bhattacharyya letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: Canadian immigration authorities have increased the amount of reserve funds required for international students applying for a study permit from this month onward.

The new requirements went into effect for those applying on September 1 or after. For those who applied earlier, the amount of financial support required to be proven by a single applicant was CA\$ 22,895. That amount has been increased to CA\$ 23,448.

This amount excludes the cost of tuition or transportation to Canada.

Overall, the applicant will

have to prove they have "enough money, without working in Canada, to pay for" tuition fees for the course or programme of studies, living expenses for the applicant and their accompanying family members, and transportation to and from Canada.

The financial capacity requirement also stipulates the applicant must provide documents proving the funds are available for the first year of studies, and how they will pay for the full duration of the course if it is longer than that.

Increasing the cost-of-living was among the initial measures the Canadian government adopted as it attempted to temper the intake of international students.

RUSSIA HELPING IRAN DEVELOP SUPERSONIC CRUISE MISSILES

LONDON: Russia has allegedly been secretly helping Iran develop advanced supersonic cruise missiles under a multi-year covert programme, in what the FT reported as one of the most significant known transfers of strategic military technology from Moscow to Tehran.

According to FT, the programme, codenamed C430L, began in 2023 and involves some of Russia's most experienced missile specialists. It aims to help Iran develop a ramjet propulsion system that could enable cruise missiles to travel at several times the speed of sound. It said that the programme continued during the Iran war.

HT

Putin, Xi discussed Trump trilateral possibility: Russia
MOSCOW/HONG KONG/BEIJING: The presidents of Russia and China discussed the possibility of trilateral talks with Donald Trump at the November APEC meet, the Kremlin's foreign policy aide, Yuri Ushakov said. The idea came up at talks between Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the SCO summit in Kyrgyzstan, he said.

S Africa clears diplomat over Zuma-Gupta meet
JOHANNESBURG: South Africa said Wednesday it had cleared its top envoy in India of involvement in meetings between ex-president Jacob Zuma and one of the Gupta brothers accused of stealing millions from state assets.

NYC bans AI for students through eighth grade
NEW YORK: Public schools in New York City, America's largest school district, will temporarily ban students in elementary and middle schools from using AI tools in the upcoming school year, Zohran Mamdani said on Wednesday.

10 missing as two ships collide off Istanbul, 1 sinks
ISTANBUL: A Turkish cargo ship that was carrying rolled steel sank in the Marmara Sea near Istanbul after colliding with an empty oil tanker, with rescuers searching for its 10 crew members, officials said Wednesday.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Banks' CD rates dip as FCNR flows hit \$127 bn

Subhasha Shalikh

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MUMBAI: A torrent of dollar deposits has crashed short-term borrowing costs for banks, as India's ambitious plan targeting overseas citizens closes with a resounding success.

Interest rates on certificates of deposit (CDs) which banks issue for short-term funds have fallen since the Reserve Bank of India incentivized dollar deposits and borrowings, showed data from Crest Finserv, an inter-dealer broking firm. Rates on three-month CDs have cooled to 6.3% against 7.09-7.23% when RBI announced the scheme on 5 June, and 7.30-8.00% at the end of March.

The central bank said on Wednesday that the scheme brought in a total of \$126.4 billion till August 31 when its FCNR(B) component ended. Of this, foreign currency non-resident Indian (FCNR(B)) that targets dollar deposits from non-resident Indians fetched \$127.2 billion or about 93.3%, while overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFBs) contributed \$5.3 billion and external commercial borrowings (ECBs) \$3.9 billion.



The scheme mobilised \$136.4 billion by August 31, when its FCNR(B) component came to an end.

As liquidity swelled, touching \$7.8 lakh crore on September 1 from \$1.85 lakh crore on June 5, rates cooled in the CD market. Central Bank of India on Tuesday raised \$1,000 crore by issuing CDs maturing on December 2 at 6.38%, compared to \$500 crore it raised at 6.60% on August 27 for a similar maturity. On March 6, the bank had raised \$250 crore through three-month CDs at 7.15%, Crest Finserv data showed.

"CD rates have fallen because banks are flush with FCNR(B) inflows and overall system liquidity has risen substantially, reducing the need to raise funds through CDs. Lower issuance is also putting downward

pressure on CD rates," said Gopal Tripathi, treasury head at Jana Small Finance Bank. The RBI introduced the swap window allowing banks to offer interest rates as high as 7.10% on 3- to 5-year foreign currency deposits for NRIs by covering the banks' currency exchange costs. The scheme also allowed NRIs to make leveraged deposits, increasing its allure. The scheme drew an earlier effort in 2013, when Indian banks successfully raised \$26 billion in foreign inflows.

The surplus funds have sharply reduced banks' dependence on CDs. In August, banks raised \$68,130 crore through CDs, lower than the \$95,945

crore raised in July, according to data from Primedatabase.com. The RBI's August bulletin noted the trend, stating CD rates softened in the second half of July and August as improved liquidity and FCNR(B) inflows reduced banks' dependence on CDs.

CDs are short-term debt instruments that banks issue to raise funds, typically from institutional investors.

Banks had increased their reliance on CDs as retail deposit growth struggled to keep pace with credit demand, using the wholesale funding route to bridge the gap and support loan growth. However, with the surge in FCNR(B) inflows, banks are now flush with funds and their need to raise money through CDs has fallen sharply, reducing CD issuance and pushing rates lower.

Total liquidity infusion through the RBI's 5 June measures is estimated at \$3.6 lakh crore over June 5 to August 14 and liquidity could peak at \$9.9 lakh crore in September before gradually declining to \$5.4 lakh crore by March 2027 as currency leakage rises and the balance of payments moves closer to neutral, according to a August 27 report by IDFC First Bank.

US, India working on fair, reciprocal trade ties: Gor

Rajeev Jayaswal

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Sergio Gor, US Ambassador to India.

NEW DELHI: India and the United States are working to build a "fair, reciprocal and mutually beneficial" trade relationship, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said on Wednesday, ahead of Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal's expected visit to the US later this month.

"The US-India relationship stands at a historic high point. Pick any sector and the United States and India are working together on it," Gor said at the 66th annual session of the Automotive Component Manufacturers Association (ACMA) in New Delhi, attended by Goyal and British Deputy High Commissioner Harinder Kang.

Gor said cooperation between the two countries extended from information technology and data centres to pharmaceuticals, defence sales and military exercises.

He also pointed to potential cooperation in space, citing NASA's invitation to ISRO to participate in its Moon Base programme.

"Our two governments are working closely together to build a trade relationship that is fair, reciprocal and mutually beneficial," Gor said.

Goyal will travel to the US at the end of the month to "con-

tinues are partnering on virtually everything," he said.

On market access, as the two governments work on the details of their trade relationship, Gor said the principle had to apply in both directions. "I want to underscore that fair market access cuts both ways," he said, stressing the need for an environment in which US suppliers and technology can access the Indian market while Indian companies can compete fairly in the US.

Goyal, speaking at the event, recalled the 65th ACMA annual session on September 12, 2025, which he attended with European Union Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič. He said Gor's presence at this year's event was "special" because the India-EU trade negotiations had advanced after last year's meeting, and expressed hope that the India-US BTA would also be concluded soon.

India and the EU concluded negotiations for a free trade agreement on January 27, 2026. The agreement is expected to be signed after legal review and the necessary regulatory approvals, according to the government.

India and the US have been negotiating a bilateral trade agreement since Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump met in Washington on February 13, 2025.

"Our progress extends well beyond trade in goods. Our two

time engaging" as the country hosts G20 talks, he added.

According to people familiar with the matter, Goyal is expected to visit the US for the G20 Trade Ministerial in Milwaukee beginning September 30. He is expected to meet his US counterpart on the sidelines of the two-day meeting and may discuss the proposed interim bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

The agreement is expected to be signed after legal review and the necessary regulatory approvals, according to the government.

India and the US have been negotiating a bilateral trade agreement since Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump met in Washington on February 13, 2025.

"Our progress extends well beyond trade in goods. Our two

JCR UPGRADES INDIA'S CREDIT RATING TO A-

Subhash Narayan

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NEW DELHI: Japan Credit Rating Agency Ltd (JCR) on Wednesday upgraded India's sovereign credit rating by a notch to A- from BBB+, citing the economy's sustained high growth, the effectiveness of its economic policies, stronger financial system and improving quality of government expenditure.

JCR had maintained the BBB+ rating for India since 2007, including during the global financial crisis, the pandemic, and subsequent geopolitical disruptions.

The agency also raised India's country ceiling by one notch to A, reflecting its assessment that India's economic fundamentals, policy framework, fiscal trajectory and financial-sector resilience have strengthened sufficiently to warrant a higher sovereign credit standing.

It assigned a stable outlook to both India's foreign-currency and local-currency long-term issuer ratings.

The upgrade comes as India continues to retain its position as the fastest-growing major economy, expanding at a high pace despite a turbulent global environment marked by geopolitical conflicts, elevated energy prices and concerns over a weaker-than-normal monsoon.

JCR said India's economy has maintained growth of around 7%, supported by robust private consumption and public investment.

It said the economy grew by 7.7% in 2025-26, and it is expected to maintain high growth of over 6% in fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

Already, signs of stronger growth are evident in the first-quarter gross domestic product (GDP) numbers announced by the ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI), which put the country's growth at 7.8%, higher than that of any other economy globally.

The ratings agency said the resilience of growth was particularly significant given the external environment.

Govt may exempt high-tech firms from BIS certification

Press Trust of India

feedback@liveinmint.com

NEW DELHI: The government is looking up with a new regulation to exempt high-tech sector companies from mandatory Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) certification for equipment and components needed to set up manufacturing facilities in India. Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Wednesday.

The challenges in getting the certification were raised by Japanese firms from the semiconductor sector during the recent visit of the minister to Tokyo.

A company in the semiconductor sector needs around 13,500 components to manufacture a semiconductor chip and the Japanese firms stated that obtaining BIS approvals for such a large number of components is a major challenge, he said.

Government defends GDP methodology, revisions

Bankikar Pattanayak & Subhash Narayan

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NEW DELHI: The government on Wednesday defended its methodology for estimating national income and the June-quarter growth rate, saying revisions to 2025-26 GDP and divergence between price gauges reflect updated data and methods, rather than an attempt to mechanically inflate the figures. The ministry of statistics and programme implementation

(MoSPI) issued a detailed clarification in a question-and-answer format, refuting allegations of artificially pushing up the real growth rate for the three months through June 7.8% and the nominal expansion rate to 10.3%.

The statistics ministry on 31 August released an updated series of annual and quarterly GDP estimates, with 2022-23 as the base year, and rolled out a new Producer Price Index, Banking Services Price Index, and additional administrative data. The ministry said the nominal

GDP for the first quarter of 2026-27 was initially estimated at \$86.05 lakh crore under the old 2011-12 base-year series. Following the introduction of the new GDP series with 2022-23 as the base year in February 2026, the estimate was revised to \$80.32 lakh crore, and subsequently to \$80.44 lakh crore on 5 June based on the latest data.

Once the new series for the Index of Industrial Production and the Industrial Price Index became available, the nominal GDP estimate was revised to \$80

lakh crore. "Thus, the movement from \$86.05 lakh crore to \$80.00 lakh crore is the result of successive revisions to the GDP series arising from the change in the base year, incorporation of improved data sources and methodologies, and update of available indicators," the ministry said. "It is therefore incorrect to interpret the difference as a deliberate downward revision of last fiscal year's GDP to mechanically increase the current year's growth rate," it added.

It underscored that the old

nominal GDP estimate of \$86.05 lakh crore for the June quarter of the FY26 cannot be directly compared with the first quarter of FY27 GDP of \$88.27 lakh crore because they belong to different GDP series. It also clarified that the 2.5% implied GDP inflation rate in the Q1 cannot be compared directly with Consumer Price Index-linked inflation of 3.9% or Wholesale Price Index-linked inflation of over 9%, as the GDP deflator covers the entire economy and reflects more than 300 individual price deflators.

IOC, BPCL REJIG OIL IMPORTS ON WARE DISRUPTIONS

Bloomberg

feedback@liveinmint.com

Oil shipments to India have been disrupted by a resurgence of fighting in the Middle East, with at least two refineries forced to arrange more costly, alternative cargoes after planned deliveries didn't arrive on time.

State-run Bharat Petroleum Corp. had four Persian Gulf cargoes that weren't delivered on schedule in August, according to people familiar with the matter, who asked not to be named discussing commercial matters. Separately, Indian Oil Corp. has also seen its delivery schedules getting changed, they said.

The sudden disruptions have forced local refiners to seek other crude supplies at short notice, which contributed to a recent flurry of purchase tenders and cargo solicitations, according to separate people familiar with the trades, the company asked not to be named due to the sensitivity of the matter.

ONGC REVIEWS VENEZUELA ASSETS AFTER US NOD

A team from the international investment arm of India's Oil & Natural Gas Corp. has arrived in Venezuela to review assets in the country, according to people familiar with the matter, weeks after the company received a green light from the US.

During a seven-day stay that began on Tuesday, a team of nearly a dozen officials from state-run ONGC Videsh Ltd., or OVL, plans to see oil fields and meet Venezuelan energy officials, the people said. It will be the first such visit in years, they added. OVL received the US government's approval in July, a step that removes sanctions-related restrictions and allows the company to resume oil and gas operations in Venezuela, where it owns stakes in San Cristobal and Carabobo project. OVL is in discussions to sign a framework agreement with Venezuela and is keen to become operator of both the projects, the company's managing director, Rajarshi Gupta, told reporters in New Delhi earlier. "We do believe both the assets have substantial chance and possibility of multi-producing production." **BLOOMBERG**

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

- What it takes to make a sewer work well? (11)
- Under cover donors 1 changed (7)
- Broad road lacking a place to meet (5)
- High spots of a European tour (4)
- Abandoned flapper in an extreme position (4)
- One who may thrive on complaints (6)
- It is weighed by a craftsman (6)
- More than father I had been unduly revered (8)
- Bleken out left for examination (4)
- In no need to enjoy life I reckon (5)
- Bizarre form of basic heating (7)
- Sounds like narrow waters but don't be confused (3,8)

DOWN

- Finally attain a high position (3,2)
- Damn peculiar mood (4)
- Chop tree as festival season arrives (6)
- Hot-red driving is completely absorbing (8)
- Reminds the end of a language (7)
- Ordering a drink and noticing its ingredients (3,3,3)
- He holds a record in business (6,5)
- It's soothing when you have to concentrate (8)
- Box me up inside and dispose of the body (7)
- Dead leads to doctor being held in row (6)
- Point out affluent German kingdom (5)
- Mist sorted for West African country (4)

{ PUZZLE 17581 }

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QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

- Genre of reconciliation (5,6)
- A radioactive metallic element (7)
- Unusually plentiful (6)
- Object of ridicule (4)
- Engine without slackening (4,2)
- Narrow band of fabric (6)
- Extreme fear and (6)
- Having special aptitude (8)
- Objective (4)
- Days (5)
- Surrounding (7)
- Requiring attention (2,3,6)

DOWN

- Spring (5)
- Empty space (4)
- Unusually approved (6)
- Generally approved (8)
- Person in charge of museum (7)
- Endorse routinely (6-5)
- Fine ornate handwriting (11)
- First-rate (3-4)
- Uncoloured gold or silver bars (7)
- Western US state (6)
- Continuously (2,3)
- Competent (4)

{ YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17580) }

CRYPTIC

QUICK

{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★

3	9		7		1	6		
			3					4
2		4		8	7			
4	3					9	8	
		9			3	6		
7		1						
9				5				
8	4		6		7	3		

Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE HIGH + LOW

THURSDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
or drizzle
29°C | 21°C

FRIDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
or drizzle
29°C | 21°C

SATURDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
or drizzle
29°C | 21°C

{ ALMANAC }

Today is 3rd September 2026
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© World
© Krishna Pancha, 2018

☀️ Sunset: Thursday 18:20
☀️ Sunrise: Friday 05:20
🌙 Moonset: Thursday 01:04 pm

{ TEMPERATURE IN METROS }

Delhi 35°C | 24°C
Mumbai 35°C | 27°C
Kolkata 31°C | 22°C
Chennai 37°C | 28°C
Bengaluru 29°C | 21°C

Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



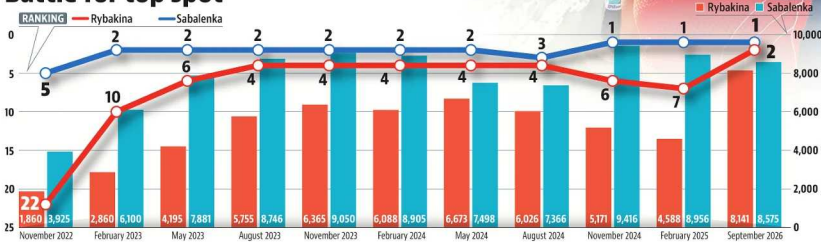
HT wknd

A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY

DUBAI: India will need to sort out their batting frailties for a more complete performance when they face Hong Kong in their second match of the Women's T20 Asia Cup on Thursday. The seven-time champions, who won four Asia Cup titles in the ODI format and three in the T20 format, survived some anxious moments after a batting collapse in the second half of the first innings in their opening match against Thailand. Although it did not affect the outcome of the match as India comfortably defeated Thailand by 94 runs, the collapse left them with a lot to ponder, as against a top team, it could prove costly.

Rybakina's own body held up quite well during the 74-minute encounter, which she began with a double fault, ended with an ace and showed unhampered movement in between. That's a big positive for the Australian Open champion after the injury in her left ankle, specifically the tendon attached to the bone as she revealed in the post-match press



"I think I was just trying not to panic," Gauff said. "She started coming to the net and playing great tennis. That 3-all game was real important," added Gauff, who saved three break points in the sixth game and broke in the next for a lead she wouldn't relinquish.

I didn't have a strong will to win, had to learn it: Praggnanandhaa

In an interview with HT, Praggnanandhaa speaks about growing up in the public eye, evolving as a player, the most expensive things he owns and making friends at gym

Susan Ninan

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BENGALURU: Praggnanandhaa returned to his hotel room and played himself across his bed the night of his Grand Chess Tour win. He had spent a month living at the same hotel, in the same city - St Louis, Missouri. He chuckles that might have been a bit much had it not been for the results he won two of the three tournaments.

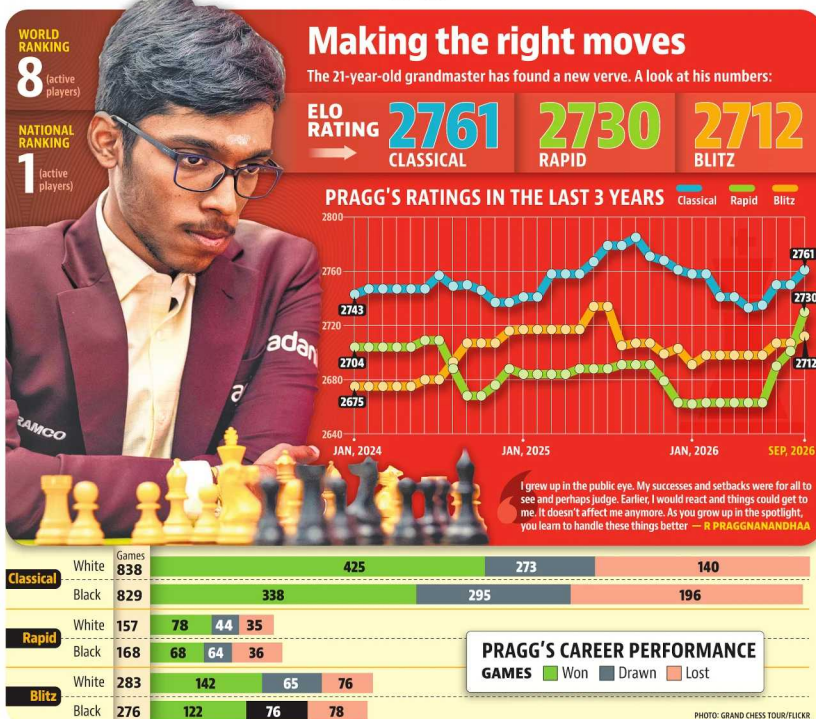
The 21-year-old is back home in Chennai, playing pickleball and catching his breath before he heads to Uzbekistan for the Olympiad in mid-September. He is candid, pensive and characteristically droll as he talks about his recent run, growing up in the public eye and evolving as a player. "I'm not someone who was naturally ambitious. I didn't have a strong will to win," Praggnanandhaa told HT in an interview.

"If you look at guys like Gukesh and Arjun (Ergaisi), they were winning tournaments as they were coming up. I didn't have that. Winning tournaments wasn't really my focus. My approach was 'If I have a chance, I'll try to win, it wasn't something I was chasing right from the start'."

That changed towards the end of 2024. In January 2025, he won his first major tournament, the Tata Steel Chess Tournament in Wijk aan Zee, defeating then newly-crowned world champion Gukesh in the playoff. "It's something I had to learn. I had to build that mindset. Now it's becoming easier. I can push myself."

It took some tinkering to get there. "There comes a stage where you give up, but you have to push yourself constantly. A few days may go your way, but you just keep pushing until it becomes second nature. There were periods where I lost games because I was over-pushing or was making risks and I wasn't being careful in my openings and certain positions. All those little experiments helped. I learnt from them."

It's going swimmingly well. He won the Saint Louis Rapid and Blitz last month and became



the first Indian to win the Grand Chess Tour, just months after his stunning Norway Chess triumph, where he defeated world No.1 Magnus Carlsen twice. At world No. 8, he's now India's highest-ranked player, returning to the world's top 10 and a grandmaster two years later. "I grew up in the public eye. My successes and setbacks were for all to see and perhaps judge. Earlier, I would react and things could get to me. It doesn't affect me anymore. As you grow up in the spotlight, you learn to handle these things better — R PRAGGNANANDHA

A part of him wishes he had this form at the Candidates tournament earlier this year. "My focus was getting to the Candidates through the FIDE circuit. I played so many classical tournaments back-to-back, there was no one else even trying to attempt it. I prepared well, I was in good shape before the Candidates and also started

with a win. Everything felt like it was going well and then it didn't go my way. It still hurts because for two years you think about this one thing and suddenly it's over and I wasn't even close to getting a chance. I don't want to think about the next cycle already. It's too much."

Praggnanandhaa had the spotlight trained on him ever since he became the world's youngest International Master at 10 and a grandmaster two years later. "I grew up in the public eye. My successes and setbacks were for all to see and perhaps judge. Earlier, I would react and things could get to me. It doesn't affect me anymore. As you grow up in

the spotlight, you learn to handle these things better."

Apart from his trainer Vaibhav Sarin, he leans on his mentor RB Ramesh. "He's my go-to guy," Praggnanandhaa says. At home, his go-to person is his sister, Vaisali, who will compete at the Women's World Championship next year. After his Rapid and Blitz win in Saint Louis, the siblings found time for the latest Spider-Man movie.

Praggnanandhaa came from the Grand Chess Tour with a title and winnings totalling a whopping four crores. "I'm glad there's money coming in which my dad handles entirely. I'm not into buying expensive things. The most

expensive things I own are probably my laptop, phone and Whoop. I'm not much into Whoop, but okay, it's something I use."

He agrees there's a trade-off involved in living this life. His rare avatars of socialising with people outside chess is at the gym. "It's nice to meet new people, have new conversations. I enjoy it. Most of them are aware of who I am and what I do."

"Whatever I have, it's not a normal life of a 21-year-old. I don't really have friends outside chess. Someone my age would like to go out, be with friends maybe party or whatever else."

Even when I'm in Chennai, I hardly go out. I'm completely focused on this one thing, which is chess. I don't really regret or miss having friends outside chess, but it would be nice to have them perhaps. But I'm happy where I am. It's just something that I have to give up to get to where I want to be."

"Chess teaches you to be resilient, to be responsible for your decisions. You make a poor one and you're worse on the board right away. You fight back, and again you're better. It resembles life. It's possible I would have learnt it doing something else, but chess teaches you these things in best possible way."

Have fun with facts on Sundays

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT FIRST VOICE LAST WORD

BCCI meet likely to focus on players' fitness crisis, Rohit

Rasesh Mandani

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MUMBAI: The who is who of Indian men's cricket, including coach Gautam Gambhir, chief selector Ajit Agarkar, Centre of Excellence head VVS Laxman, Test and ODI captain Shubman Gill and T20I captain Shreyas Iyer will join BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia, the convenor, in a stock-taking meeting at the board's Mumbai headquarters on Thursday.

The meeting is expected to review and look ahead in an attempt to address bottlenecks in planning and improve coordination between these key functional areas. It will look back at the recent past where the T20I team suffered a shock 0-2 series defeat to Ireland and was trounced 0-4 by England. It will also review inconsistent ODI results where three of the last five series were lost against Australia, New Zealand and England.

All the key stakeholders would want to look ahead to the upcoming Test series — away against New Zealand and at home against Australia — with better planning. While the T20I final appears to be a tall order, getting back to winning ways in Tests and regaining home dominance is a necessity.

There is a word of concern from the selection room over a growing trend of players being unable to regain full fitness from injuries within expected timelines. Of late, there have been instances of a number of players, after being passed fit, breaking down during international ties. After being cleared following IPL, Nitish Reddy missed the Afghanistan ODI series in June with a left quad injury. Harshit Rana and Yuvraj Chahal were out during the England T20Is in July with hamstring injuries, and Washington Sundar was ruled out with a right hamstring injury from the following ODIs in England.

After this, the COE has become extra sensitive with return-to-play protocols, leaving selectors to pick players with a "subject to fitness" asterisk.

Sai Sudharsan and Jasprit Bumrah were selected subject to fitness for the recent Sri Lanka Tests but never made it. Washington too has been picked subject to fitness for the Afghanistan T20Is along with Bumrah, Rana and Reddy.

The COE has been without a sports science head for nearly 18 months. It is expected of the COE medical team to tilt the selectors whether a player is fit to be picked or not and the risks involved. With no one of authority accountable for the call, they end up being non-committal, a BCCI functionary told HT.

These matters BCCI is well aware of. Last month, Saikia and Laxman told the media about suitable candidates for the post of sports science head with sports-fitness expertise unwilling to relocate to Bengaluru where COE is based. Although the meeting is unlikely to find a lasting solution, discussions at a meeting full of important people could help improve things.

Rohit Sharma's future

The immediate concern around the ODI team is the sensitive selection call on Rohit Sharma's future. It is understood the selectors had lost confidence in his ability to retain form and fitness until the next World Cup and spoke to him before the England series. The selectors and team management were under the impression that Rohit would retire after the England ODIs, but on the eve of the final ODI at Lord's, Saikia dismissed such talk as speculation.

Whether Agarkar raises the matter or BCCI intervenes after Rohit's hundred at Lord's remains to be seen. Agarkar continuing as chief selector still is a matter of discussion. He is known to have expressed a desire to end when his contract expires in September, but BCCI is yet to take a call.

India lack finishing kick with Rinku ignored again

Rasesh Mandani

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MUMBAI: India's results before and after the T20 World Cup win have been chalk and cheese. Parity, the downturn can be attributed to teething troubles for new captain Shreyas Iyer to rally his troops, but the real reason is the key position — the finisher, the selection policy on either side of the World Cup has oscillated one way, then the other.

Rinku Singh has been at the receiving end of this ambiguity, treated as a disposable asset. After losing his place midway through the T20 World Cup, Rinku was recalled for the Zimbabwe T20I series, only to be shown the door for the upcoming 3-match series in Delhi against Afghanistan. The South African against the KKR finisher when he was picked to shore up India's lower order in their World Cup plans. In his first comeback match against New Zealand at Nagpur, leading up to the World Cup, Rinku proved his chops with a 20-ball 44*. At the time, Rinku had pipped Jitesh Sharma for the finishing role, which was marked by a broader strategic pivot where Sanju Samson replaced Shubman Gill at the top.

At the World Cup, Rinku walked out to bat in either the 19th or the 20th over in three of the four league matches. He delivered counters against Pakistan and Netherlands, while he failed against Namibia. In the opening match against the USA, he couldn't help India recover lost wickets after they had lost early wickets. Another failure came against South Africa in the Super Eight's follow-up. By then, India felt the burden of their left-hand heavy top order. Samson returned in the eleven as opener and Rinku, down the order, came back on the chopping block.



Central Zone's Rinku Singh during the Duleep Trophy semi-final.

Rinku watched the rest of the World Cup from the sidelines with Samson's flying starts leading the turnaround. The UP batter was discarded for the two tours of Ireland and England that followed.

Altogether, Rinku has played in only 12 of India's 24 matches this year. In three of them, without an opportunity to bat, he faced only 109 balls, where his 152 runs came at a strike rate of 139.45. It's virtually impossible to judge a finisher by just those numbers. A more perceptive outlook would draw one towards Rinku's broader returns - SR of 143, 163 and 188 batting at No. 6 and 8 in the IPL, and SR of 165, 147 and 155 at No. 5, 6, and 7 in T20Is. This output makes Rinku one of the better finishers in India, which is why the selectors keep going back to him.

Without the brute power of an Andre Russell or Tim David, Rinku brings to the fore a wider range of hitting skills, allowing him to dissect the boundary, if not clear it at will. Under any T20 philosophy, the finisher requires both utmost trust and a long rope. Rinku has been dropped far too frequently to retain the adequacy finisher's exhibit.

For the upcoming series, Rinku

loses out with Washington Sundar (subject to fitness) returning. That's another handicap for Rinku, not of his own making: India can only afford to pick so many batters who cannot bowl in the playing eleven. The hope is that Tilak Varma, who is being groomed at No. 5, will get a hang of batting in different gears and make a habit of finishing matches like Rinku.

After Tilak, India's lower order - with Hardik Pandya's long-term availability under a fitness cloud - still lacks muscle or zing. Sundar, Shivam Dube and Asar Patel have been unable to provide the finishing kick which can often be the difference between a win and a loss.

South enter final
BENGALURU: Tilak Varma helped South enter the Duleep Trophy final with a seven-wicket win over North on the fourth and final day of the semi-final on Wednesday. Chasing 181, South got the job done in the first two sessions of the day after Tilak (51 not out) and Ravichandran Sharma (32 not out) milked 80 runs for the unbroken fourth wicket stand. They will face East in the final in Chennai from Sunday.

Asiad: Neeraj isn't going to Japan but coach, physio are

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NEW DELHI: The sports ministry on Wednesday cleared the names of 246 coaches and support staff members to accompany Indian athletes at the upcoming Asian Games that begin in Japan's Aichi-Nagoya on Sept 19. The number of athletes has also been increased from 492 (265 men and 227 women) to 503 (269 male & 234 female) following the addition of the four-member surfing team, six athletes and one Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) athlete. The total strength of the Indian contingent now stands at 768.

Praveen Kumar (Hammer throw), Haritha Bhadra (200m), Kiran Pahal (400m), Asha Banga (triple jump), Sindhu Thiruvethan (pole vault), Yadav Yadu (discus throw) are the additions to the athletes team while Varun Shanti has been added to the MMA team in the Traditional 77kg event. The surfing team comprises Kishore Kumar Anbarasu, Sivraj Babu, Kamal Prakash, and Sugar Shanti Gayen in shortboard.

The athletics squad now stands at 79 athletes and 31 officials (coaches, physios, masseuse, doctor, manager, analyst). The 30-member cricket (15 men, 15 women) team will travel with a 20-member support staff while the delegation will travel at 100's cost. A total of 19 IOA officials will travel with the Indian contingent, headed by chief of mission weightlifting federation chief Sahdev Yadav. He will be joined by four deputy chiefs de mission, Dr. Dinshaw Pardolwa as chief medical officer, one press attache, one social media attache, among others. Four IOA officials, part of the delegation, will travel at IOA's cost.

Additionally, the ministry has asked the federations to conduct background verification of officials and support staff. "In view of the disapproval of some officials' sportspersons in the foreign countries in the past, this Ministry is of the view that the backgrounds/ antecedents of the members be checked properly by NSFs concerned," the note added.

THE NUMBER OF ATHLETES HAS ALSO BEEN INCREASED FROM 492 (265 MEN AND 227 WOMEN) TO 503 (269 MALE & 234 FEMALE). THE CONTINGENT NOW STANDS AT 768

Masseuse Saishiki Aggarwal has been included under the Judo discipline but will also assist the wushu athletes, the ministry said. Interestingly, Neeraj Chopra's coach, Jai Choudhary and physio Ishaan Marwaha have been named in the list although the ace javelin thrower has ruled himself out of the Asian Games due to a ligament tear. However, Glasgow CWG medalist Yashvir Singh, who was expected to replace Chopra, did not make the list.

A total of 19 IOA officials will travel with the Indian contingent, headed by chief of mission weightlifting federation chief Sahdev Yadav. He will be joined by four deputy chiefs de mission, Dr. Dinshaw Pardolwa as chief medical officer, one press attache, one social media attache, among others. Four IOA officials, part of the delegation, will travel at IOA's cost. A total of 19 IOA officials will travel with the Indian contingent, headed by chief of mission weightlifting federation chief Sahdev Yadav. He will be joined by four deputy chiefs de mission, Dr. Dinshaw Pardolwa as chief medical officer, one press attache, one social media attache, among others. Four IOA officials, part of the delegation, will travel at IOA's cost.

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